The Knesset Building in Giv'at Ram: Planning and Construction

Originally published in Cathedra Magazine, 96th Edition, July 2000

Written by Dr. Susan Hattis Rolef

Introduction

Already in the early days of modern Zionism, it was clear to those who envisioned the establishment of a Jewish State, and those who acted to realize the vision, that once it was established, it would be a democracy, in which a parliament would be built. In his book *Altneuland* (written in 1902), Theodor Herzl, described the parliament of the Jewish state in Jerusalem in the following words: "[A] great crowd was massed before (the Congress House). The election was to take place in the lofty council chamber built of solid marble and lighted from above through matte glass. The auditorium seats were still empty, because the delegates were still in the lobbies and committee rooms, engaged in exceedingly hot discussion…" [1]

In his book *Yerushalayim Habnuya* (written in 1918), Boris Schatz, who had established the Bezalel school of arts and crafts, placed the parliament of the Jewish State on Mount Olives: "Mount Olives ceased to be a mountain of the dead… it is now the mountain of life…the round building close to [the Hall of Peace] is our parliament, in which the Sanhedrin sits".[2] When in the 1920s the German born architect, Richard Kaufmann, presented to the British authorities his plan for the Talpiot neighborhood, that was designed to be a Jerusalem garden neighborhood, it included an unidentified building of large dimensions. When he was asked about the meaning of the building he relied in German: "this is our parliament building". Upon the advice of the British, who considered this a megalomanic fantasy, he changed the identity of the building to an art gallery.[3] How Kaufmann envisioned his parliament - we shall never know. Herzl was inaccurate in his description of the building, and Schatz and Kaufmann were both wrong in their location of the building. Nevertheless, as visionaries, all three deserve to be mentioned at the opening of an article dealing with the planning and construction of the Knesset building in Jerusalem.[4]



One of the paintings of Theodor Herzl in the Knesset: An oil painting by Baron Joseph Arpad Koppay von Dretoma, 1899



Boris Schatz, self-portrait. The Schatz Fund.

The Need to Construct a Permanent Building for the Knesset, 1949-1955

As early as April 1949, when the basic planning of the government complex on Sheikh Baader Hill (Givat Ram) began,[5] the architect Arie Sharon, who stood at the head of the Planning Section,[6] proposed that the permanent Knesset building would be located at the Northern plateau of the hill, together with the "Congress Hall" (Binyanei Ha'uma).[7] Twenty five years later an ideological explanation was given to this idea: "The symbolic intention was to create a close connection between the Knesset, which is the parliament of the Jewish people in Israel, and Binyanei Ha`uma, which constitutes the meeting place of the Zionist Congresses and Conferences of the Jews of the dispersions".[8] In November 1949, Mordechai Shatner, who was chairman of the Committee for the Development of the Government Buildings (that later turned into the Complex Committee), reported to the Government Secretary, Ze'ev Sherf, that Knesset Speaker Joseph Sprinzak, and members of the Knesset secretariat, had toured the area designated for the complex with members of the Committee, and that the location of the Knesset had been agreed upon.[9] In the plan that on April 25, 1950 won first prize in the competition for the planning of the government complex, which had been submitted by the architects Munio Gitai Weinraub and Al Mansfeld,[10] the location of the Knesset was at a distance of around 200 meters from Binyanei Ha'uma, but within the complex, on the North-Western side of what was known as "the representational square" (one of two squares in the complex - the Southern one designed for parades), together with the President's residence and the Prime Minister's Office. But very soon this planned was shelved, and according to a map of the government complex, that bears the date of September 6, 1950, the Knesset appears elsewhere: in the center of the complex, on the South-Eastern side of a single central square, around which the Prime Minister's Office, the Ministry for Foreign Affairs and the Ministry of Finance are also located.[11] On this map the President's residence is on a separate hill, on the South-Eastern corner of the complex - the hill on which the Knesset itself was finally built. Over the next four and a half years, it was this plan that was deliberated by the Government Complex Committee.[12]



The original plan for the Government complex in Givat Ram by the architects Al Mansfeld and Munio Gitai Weinraub, that won the competition in 1950



A contemporary map drawn on the basis of the plan for the Government complex area, September 1950

On February 1, 1952, Shlomo Arazi, the Director of the Government Complex Bureau, informed Ephraim Evron, Prime Minister David Ben Gurion's private secretary, that "regarding the central block, which includes the Knesset building, the Prime Minister's Office, the Ministry for Foreign Affairs and the Ministry of Finance, it is intended to hold, at the end of this year, a competition for planning the area and the buildings, in such a way that it will be possible to start the actual building in 1954".[13] In the middle of 1952 it was still taken for granted that these buildings would be built around a central square, and in several meetings of the Complex Committee the question of whether the planning of the square and the Knesset building should come first, or whether all the buildings should be planned simultaneously, was deliberated. The main consideration was budgetary.

"I think", said the Chairman of the Committee, Shatner, at the Committee meeting of May 13, 1952, "that even if we decide to plan the Knesset only, it will be necessary to determine, not only height, but also the contours for the other buildings, and if it will be necessary to calculate the contour and height, it is worth planning the whole area, if this will not take too much time". The Secretary General of the Knesset, Moshe Rosseti, added that "there is no doubt that we cannot approach this issue without planning the whole square, to the very last detail, so that there will be harmony among the buildings, and that we should not create a situation in which each building will be built over the years in a different architectural style". Arazi interpreted the words of the Secretary General: "Mr. Rosseti was undoubtedly referring to the city of Cardiff (in Britain), where a square was planned in the center of the city, and various buildings were built around it in different periods, and by different bodies. Each one of them separately is very nice, but they do not blend properly with each other".[14]

It is curious that at this stage, the architect Joseph Klarwein, who was eventually to win first prize in the competition for the planning of the Knesset building, and who served as an advisor to the Complex Committee, thought that one should not yet start building the Knesset building. "I think, that the time has not come to build a Knesset, as long as we do not yet have a constitution in the country that lays down the form of the people's representation: one House or two Houses?"[15]

On June 2, 1952, a short time after this meeting took place, Sprinzak wrote an emotional letter to Prime Minister David Ben Gurion. "I should like to ask you to raise the issue of a suitable residence for the Knesset in one of the Government meetings devoted to a deliberation on the development budget", he wrote, "so that the Government will consider the need to earmark money for this purpose. Since March 1950 the Knesset has resided in 'Beit Frumin' [on King George Street], which was requisitioned for it for a short period, and which is unsuited, in all respects, to its needs. The Knesset resides in this building under the assumption that it will serve as a temporary residence, and that before long it will be able to move to a more suitable building".

Sprinzak told Ben Gurion that in August 1950 a contract had been signed with the Economic Corporation for the Development of Jerusalem, to rent the Beit Ha'am (cultural center) building in the center of town, for a period of around three years "until its permanent building would be constructed in the complex", but finally those in charge of the work of the Knesset reached the conclusion "that the Beit Ha'am building will not solve the problem of the Knesset's residence, and will not satisfy its requirements".[16] It is doubtful whether at the time of writing the letter to Ben Gurion, Sprinzak imagined that the Knesset would continue to reside in Beit Frumin, for anther fourteen years; He certainly did not imagine the course of obstacles that the planners and constructors of the Knesset building would have to undergo until the new building would be inaugurated on the South-Eastern corner of the government complex on August 30, 1966.

In February 1955 the Government finally adopted an operative decision regarding the construction of "an independent building for the Knesset".[17] But before this happened there were two additional plans for a temporary residence for the Knesset: the first in one of the buildings (building No. 3) planned in the government complex,[18] and the second in Binyanei Ha`uma. The idea of putting the Knesset in Binyanei Ha`uma[19] (the construction of which was in the basic frame stage), was rejected in an opinion presented on December 12, 1953 by the architects Dov Karmi, Klarwein and Jacob Pinkerfeld, to the Government Secretary Sherf. One of their arguments was that it is not desirable "to locate the Knesset in a public building that has its own designations, such as: conferences, concerts, exhibitions, fairs etc."[20] The idea was finally rejected in the beginning of 1955, after it became known that the Jewish Agency - the owner of Binyanei Ha`uma - refuses to make it available to the Knesset.[21]

The idea of building the Knesset in the midst of the government complex, on the central square, finally fell through, after it was agreed that even if the Knesset would form part of the complex, it should be located on its periphery. On March 29, 1955, at the second meeting of the Program Committee - the Committee, which had been set up in order to prepare the architectural program for the Knesset building towards the competition for its planning - the Knesset representatives expressed their dissatisfaction with the site allocated for the building in the complex. Rosseti argued that it was necessary to separate the Knesset

building from the rest of the buildings in the complex, in order to give the separation of powers - the legislative authority and the executive authority - a geographical dimension. In 1953 the Knesset Serjeant-at-Arms, Lieutenant-Colonel Moshe Yona Hazor, added that even practical considerations regarding traffic arrangements, the approach to the building for the general public, and Knesset's working hours that sometimes lasted well into the night, made it necessary to construct the Knesset in an area, which can be supervised independently. He also mentioned that the regulations of the 1952 Law on the Immunity of the Knesset Buildings, grant the Knesset buildings and the area known as the Knesset foreground, special status. To sum up, the Committee decided to request that "another suitable area be found for the Knesset within the areas of the government complex, or adjacent to them".[22]

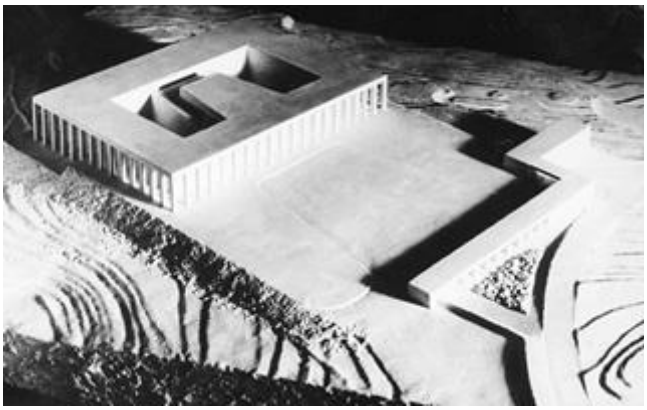
After Sprinzak and his deputies toured the government complex area in the beginning of June, the Knesset Presidium decided that the suitable place for constructing the Knesset building in the government complex was the hill, which in the original plan was designated for the President's residence. After Shatner informed Sprinzak, that the Government Complex Committee had, on June 14, 1955, approved the allocation of the area needed for the Knesset's requirements, in the South-East corner of the government complex, the Knesset Speaker announced the decision in the plenum.[23] In a press release, Sprinzak noted that in the period of the Second Temple, there had been a Jewish settlement in the designated area, the residents of which engaged primarily in stone cutting for the construction of the city of Jerusalem, and that after the destruction of the city, the tenth Roman legion camped on the site. In the Christian era there was a Christian old people's settlement on the location, and an oil-press from the period of the destruction was also found. Sprinzak added that close to the area, burial caves from the period of the Sanhedrin had been found.[24]

At this stage the preparation of the program for the building was completed. Though the representatives of the Knesset administration participated in the preparation, and even the Knesset Speaker was involved in the process, the issue was never debated in the Knesset plenum, or any of its committees.[25] The program was, in fact, a list of areas, installations and rooms that must be included in the building. In this respect the program was simple and clear, but it said nothing about its essence and the nature of the activity in the building, or the preferred architectural style.[26] Many years later, the architect Ram Karmi argued that the program was not clear, and that for this reason many architects decided not to participate in the competition.[27] The architect Heinz Rau argued that the program was ideal for a *petit-bourgeois* parliament.[28]

The Competition and its Results, mid-1956 to mid-1958

On July 25, 1956 the Knesset Presidium announced, in association with the Association of Engineers and Architects in Israel, a public competition among the state's architects, for the planning of a permanent residence for the Knesset. Since at this stage there was as yet no source of funding for the construction, and since the architects felt that the competition was a barren competition, most of the renowned architects in the country refrained from participating in it. Only nine days before the publication of the results of the competition, did it become known that the James de-Rothschild, who had died a short while previously, had left in his will a sum of £1.25 million - six million Israeli Pounds - for the construction of the Knesset.[29]

The results of the competition were published on July 24, 1957. The jury announced that it had been unanimously decided to grant the first prize to the architect Joseph Klarwein.[30] The members of the jury - among whom were Uriel Schiller, Genia Averbuch, David Anatol Brutzkus, Nahum Zelkind, Max Leob and Hanan Pavel[31] - explained their decision in that Klarwein's building "well expresses and serves its special designation by positioning it on a level the dimensions of which are not exaggerated… and by means of the noble appearance of the body of the building on all sides… The use of classical insinuations in the architectural composition bestows on the building the attribute of inspiring awe in those approaching it".[32] The members of the jury also decided not to give a second prize, since they did not find a plan that was worthy, in their opinion, of receiving this prize.



The model for the Knesset building submitted by Klarwein to the competition, 1957

On the eve of the inauguration of the Knesset building in August 1966, Yehuda Ha`ezrahi described Klarwein's original plan in the following words:
According to this plan, the building should have been constructed in the shape of a single rectangle… surrounded by a vestibule of columns in front. The columns were higher on the Southern side, on the slope of the mountain, and lower on the Northern side, at its incline. This plan is generally characterized by its simplicity, but its ornamentation is condensed into the appearance of the columns. On its basis, the Knesset walls were to have been constructed 'in depth', protected by an extending ceiling and an overhang, consequently being immersed in shade, almost hidden, while the columns stood out to their full height, visible - constituting the front of the building.[33]

An additional characteristic of the plan was the location of the plenary hall in the center of the building, with an inner court on either side - a basic layout that reminded many of the Altes Museum, constructed by Friedrich Schinkel in Berlin in the 1820s. (See below)

Soon after the results of the competition for the Knesset building were known, Uri Avnery published an article in *Ha'olam Hazeh*, with the title "The Scandal in the Knesset Building", in which he argued that in the results of the competition "there is suspicion of 'favoritism', suspicion of poor judgement, echoes of horse-trading, and manifestations of malignant sect-rule". Klarwein himself was described as a man from the establishment, favored by the establishment. Avnery presented all the arguments against the choice of

Klarwein's plan, which had been voiced at the meeting of the "Union of Architects". These included that the planned building was not modern, that it was not Israeli, that the uniformity of its form was boring, that it was neo-classical (see below), and that it did not blend into its surroundings.[34] At the end of the meeting, mentioned by Avnery, an unprecedented resolution was adopted, which was to try and thwart the construction of the Knesset building on the basis of the plan that won first prize.



“The Scandal in the Knesset Building”, a caption in Olam Hazeh on August 7, 1957. The article portrayed several of the models presented in the competition.

Finally, this resolution was revoked. After the storm and prolonged debates, the National Committee of the "Union of Architects" and the Central Committee of the "Association of Engineers and Architects" agreed that the original reaction had been exaggerated, and on September 10, 1957, a letter was sent to the Knesset Presidium, in which the Central Committee announced that the National Committee withdrew its demand. Inter alia the letter stated:
2. The Association, with all its institutions, including the Union of Architects, is united in its opinion that the competition and the judgement for the Knesset building, were run in accordance with all the rules of custom, deduced from the rules of procedure for competitions of the Association, and in full accordance with professional ethics.
3. The Central Committee points out that in accordance with the general regulations for competitions, and in accordance with the conditions of the competition for the Knesset building, upon the conclusion of the judgement, and the publication of the results of the competition, the activity of the jury ended, and from now on the direct sides to the association for the construction of the building are the customer who made the order, and the person who received the first prize. Nevertheless, the Central Committee takes special note of the decision of the jury members to appoint a construction committee, and the Central Committee will propose to the Knesset Presidium, in view of the special value of the Knesset building, that the number of members in the Committee be increased to five, and that they be given much broader powers.
4. At the same time, the Central Committee cannot ignore the deep unrest that was created within the public of architects against the implementation of the plan, which won for its author the first prize. The Central Committee states, that according to the regulations of the competition, there is no place for a revision of the decision of the jury. Nevertheless - considering the great importance of the building - the Central Committee feels obliged to bring to the attention of the Knesset Presidium that such unrest exists, and to recommend to it that the extended Committee, as proposed, should first of all concentrate on studying the plan and the criticism of it, to determine the position of the Committee regarding the demands for revision.[35]

Even though the "Association of Engineers and Architects" withdrew its original demands, the Speaker of the Knesset, Joseph Sprinzak approached the Israeli Ambassador to the United States, Abba Eban, in a letter

on November 12, 1957:

The jury that was appointed in complete accordance with the proposal of the Association of Engineers and Architects reached a unanimous decision that the first prize be given to the architect Klarwein. On the basis of the existing contract and regulations, we are bound to construct the Knesset building by Klarwein, in accordance with his own plan. It should be noted, that within the public there is sympathy for this plan - the first prize. Contrary to the decision of the jury… and the sympathy for the plan in the public, a deadly storm broke out against the plan among the architects in Israel. One might say that a public of hundreds of architects in the country almost unanimously rejects Klarwein's plan. This manifests itself in different ways, in writing and orally - some in an unworthy and vulgar manner, and some in a polite but totally negative manner, supported by objective proof regarding the essence of the building, which should be worthy of being a national building - the Knesset of Israel. Of course, one may also be suspicious of the sources of the objection by the architects of Israel to Klarwein's plan, but the fact is that the objection is total and very harsh. We are, thus, in a state of great embarrassment.[36]

Sprinzak asked Eban to help find candidates to serve on a small team of architectural experts, to decide between the position of the competition jury, and the total objection of the architects. And indeed, finally a committee of experts was set up, that included the architects Max Abramovitz from New York, Sir Howard Morley Robertson from London, and Professor Leo Arie Meir - a Professor for Near East Archeology and Art from Jerusalem. In April 1958 the Committee decided:

The concept of the winner of the prize, Mr. Klarwein, who proposed a building that excels in its simplicity and unity of image, which stands on an elevated site that expresses movement, and is located within a scenery of existing buildings with different silhouettes - is very worthy of being accepted. It can lead to an excellent strongly expressed solution, by emphasizing the contrast with the background, and to have a sublime position, that contains the possibility of being the outstanding point within the area.[37]

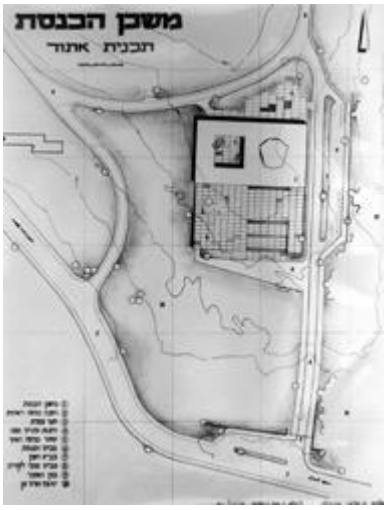
Two Wasted Years: Plans and Intrigues, mid-1958 to mid-1960

In accordance with the experts' proposal, Klarwein was sent abroad "in order to study similar buildings".[38] After his return from a trip to Europe in the beginning of November 1958, he reported to the Implementation Committee (Va'adat Habitzuah), which had been set up in June 1958 to actively follow all the stages of the planning and construction of the Knesset building,[39] that "the only thing worth seeing in Europe was the UNESCO building in Paris".[40] This building constitutes for us an example of how one can build a parliament in a manner that it was built there, without any luxuries. There is no marble in sight, everything is simple, natural and beautiful".[41]

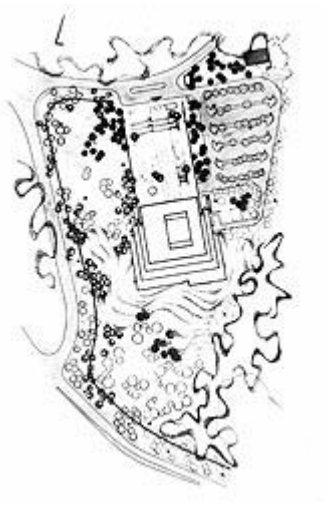
In the meantime the corner stone for the Knesset building was laid on October 14, 1959, in the presence of James de Rothschild's widow, Dorothy.

Avnery's claim that Klarwein was a man from the establishment, was unfounded. He was, indeed, employed as an advisor on the government complex project in Jerusalem (see above), and even participated in the planning of the complex, but he was in fact a loner, who frequently participated in competitions in the belief that this was the only way for an "outsider" like himself to pave a way for himself in Israeli architecture.[42] A noted establishment man, who was involved in the planning of the Knesset in the early years, was the engineer Shlomo Gur, one of those who had conceived the settlement-security concept of "Homma Umigdal" (wall and watch tower) before the establishment of the state, and had served as project manager in the construction of the Hebrew University campus at Givat Ram, and the Hadassa Medical Center in Ein Karem, in Jerusalem. Gur, who was a member of the Knesset Implementation Committee until the middle of 1960, and a dominant figure in it, said in an interview to journalist Eli Eyal, that "the idea is to start building without plans. All that is needed is someone with the power to decide, who will take the responsibility upon himself, and start the wheels moving". Eyal pointed out, that what drove Gur was the desire to live up to deadlines, and that his work methods raise "astonishment among contractors, and rejection, mixed with anxiety among architects.[43]

It seems as though Gur's main intention was to construct the building, while actually doing away with Klarwein's original plan, despite the experts' positive opinion. When Klarwein returned from his tour in Europe, he faced an unpleasant surprise. In his absence, the architect Zvi Cohen, who was brought to the project by Gur , started making far reaching changes in the original plan, without any prior consultation with Klarwein. In a letter to the Speaker of the Knesset, Kadish Luz, dated February 11, 1960, Klarwein described the chain of events. He complained that contrary to his opinion it was decided "to move the main entrance into the building from the North to the South, and instead of constructing a foreground on the Northern side, to build a terrace, supported by walls, on the Southern side, which from an architectural point of view would constitute, in fact, an additional building that would compete with the Knesset building itself." He added, that while he had been in Europe, the front of the building had been lengthened from 86 to 120 meters, excavations had commenced in accordance with the elongated dimensions, and the earth, which had been removed, was being used to change the incline of the hill on which the building was to be constructed. In addition, excavations had begun in order to pave an approach road from the direction of Rupin Road in the South, instead of from the North, as planned.[44]

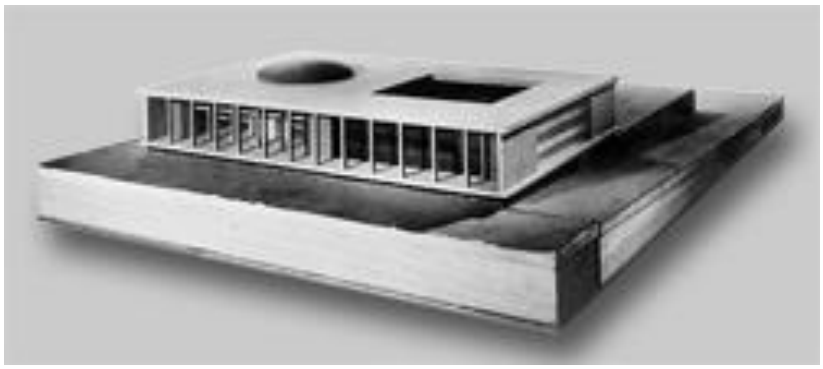


The plan prepared by Klarwein and Powsner in June 1959. The building is situated at the northern edge of the compound, and the entrance to the building is from the South



The final plan of the Knesset building, towards the end of the construction

Professor Yohanan Ratner,[45] who had been coopted to the Implementation Committee as an advisor, explained the chain of events, from his perspective, during one of the Committee's meetings in May 1959: "We have here a difficult psychological situation. The cause for this psychological situation… is Klarwein… On the one hand Klarwein received the first prize, and on the other, most of the architects in the country protested against it. The reasons do not matter. To get rid of him, means starting a new competition - something nobody wanted… So we started to seek compromises". One of the ways to get out of the labyrinth, Ratner explained, "was to send Klarwein abroad. The second way was that even before his trip, Mr. Klarwein agreed to the setting up of an office which would be headed by the [Tel Aviv architect Shimon] Powsner[46] … Klarwein was incapable of turning his plan into a good building… There Powsner was one of the mediums, who was able to turn Klarwein's concept into something more reasonable".[47]



The model prepared by Klarwein and Powsner in June 1959

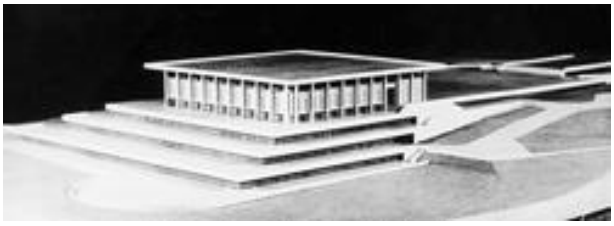
In March 1959, Klarwein and Powsner presented two separate proposals to the Implementation Committee. Robertson and Abramowitz, who were asked to express an opinion on the plans, argued that Powsner's plan, in which much glass was used, was too light, while Klarwein's plan was too heavy, and that the two ought to be combined.[48] On June 22, 1959, the Implementation Committee received a new plan prepared by Powsner and Klarwein together.[49] In the new plan the building lost its symmetry. The plenary hall, designed as a circle, was moved from the center of the building to its Eastern side,[50] and one of the inner courts was cancelled. The columns on the two sides of the building were also done away with, in order to limit the dimensions of the building, and the number of columns at the front and in back, was limited from twenty to fourteen. Despite Klarwein's reservations, the building was shifted Northwards, and the entrance was left on the South.[51]

Regarding the change in the location of the building, the Implementation Committee came across opposition from the Government Complex Committee. In a letter to the Knesset Speaker, Nahum Nir, Shatner complained on August 6, 1959, that contrary to the agreements of December 22, 1958, the Implementation Committee was not coordinating its plans with the Government Complex Committee, and the representatives of the Jerusalem municipality. "The Knesset building is not being constructed as a single building in an undeveloped site, and its planning must integrate into the general planning", he wrote. "This does not mean that we wish to deal with all sorts of architectural issues, but only with the construction plan".[52]

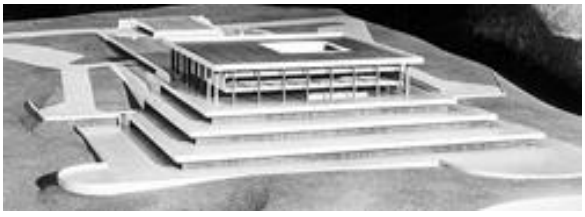
Regarding the direction of the entrance, a serious debate took place in the Implementation Committee. The main arguments in favor of the entrance from the North were the fact that those entering the building would be unable to see the view on the South; the advantage of entering the building directly, without many steep stairs that a Southern entrance would have necessitate; the possibility of constructing separate entrances into the building, one for the public and one for the Knesset Members at different levels; and that the Knesset would thus form an integral part of the government complex, to its West. The main arguments in favor of the entrance from the South - the direction preferred by most of the members of the Implementation Committee - was the beautiful view seen from that direction, the monumentality of the front of the building, as seen by the person entering the building, because of the differences of height between Rupin Road and the entrance, and the emphasis on the uniqueness of the Knesset by separating it from the government complex.[53]

But what finally decided the issue, were the reservations of the IDF to the entrance being on the South. In a letter written to the Speaker of the Knesset on February 16, 1960, the head of the Operations Branch in the General Staff, Avharam (Avrasha) Tamir, stated that the entrance from this side would be dangerous, because "the location chosen for the Knesset building can be observed from several firing positions across the Jordanian border, at a range of 3,500-4,000 meters, a fact that theoretically enables the opening of flat trajectory fire - whether by intermediate machine guns or by tank artillery (direct targeting) - with a fair chance that it would hit its target".[54] The fear was especially of an attack while ceremonies were being held on the foreground of the entrance. Though Chief of Staff, Haim Laskov, told Kadish Luz that as far as the General Staff was concerned the entrance could remain on the Southern side, as long as it remained concealed,[55] the Implementation Committee had little choice but to return the entrance to the Northern side.

At around the same time, it was also decided to invite the architect Dov Karmi, winner of the Israel Prize for Architecture for the year 1957, to act as an advisor and mediator. Karmi was known as a congenial person, and the members of the Implementation Committee hoped that he would succeed where Shatner had failed - to rid the project of the bad atmosphere prevailing in it, and pull it out of the cul-de-sac it appeared to have entered. Karmi's great advantage over all the other potential candidates for the job, was that he was acceptable to Klarwein, whose suspicion toward all the other experts, seemed to grow over time.



The first model prepared by Karmi and Gillitt in 1960



The revised model by Karmi and Gillitt in 1961

Karmi prepared, together with his son Ram and the young British architect Bill Gillitt, a new plan that not only returned the building’s entrance to the North, but also moved the building slightly to the South, turned it from a rectangle to a square, decreased its circumference, and cancelled the remaining courtyard in its center. Contrary to Klarwein's original plan, the plenary hall was no longer situated in the middle of the building, because the State Hall was now situated to its West (see below). At the same time, compared to

Powsner's plan, the centrality of the plenary hall in the building was once again emphasized. At some stage between the middle of 1960 and the middle of 1962 a recess of one story was set in the roof of the building, over the location of the plenary hall, whose ceiling was designed in the form of a vault. Since the circumference of the building was reduced significantly, some of the office spaces were moved to a terrace structure on the Southern inclines of the hill on which the Knesset was built. The logic in this planning was that even if the need would arise to extend the building, and add rooms and offices to it, the central structure would remain without change, and the additions would be built around the existing building.[56] And indeed, the new wing, whose construction was completed in 1991, can be seen only in aerial photographs. Whoever views it from ground level, barely notices this wing. This was also the reason why the central building was constructed primarily of concrete and stone, and the terraces primarily of glass and stainless steel.[57]

At the beginning of March 1960, it became apparent that the entry of the Karmis into the project, turned Shimon Powsner's continued involvement in it superfluous, and after several months he left, without even beginning to work on the work plans.[58] At the same time, Gur and Ratner made a last effort to prevent the acceptance of Karmi's new plan, and to bring about the announcement of a new competition. On April 21, 1960, Ratner wrote to Gur about Karmi's plan:
It is perfectly clear that there is no similarity between this and K's original plan, or ‘the agreed plan’ of 26.6.59 [Powsner and Klarwein's plan}… By means of his agreement to a plan that was not his own, Klarwein made, in fact, several moves: a) he cancelled the plan that had won the competition; b) he justified the criticism that had been made against it by his professional peers; c) he destroyed the basis for all his emotional demands, and the complicated process by which the Implementation Committee operated, with the intention of preserving his rights and name as the architect of the building, frequently at the expense of delays, of many difficulties and of financial expenditures; d) he tried to hand over, for reasons that are not completely clear, and under a legal excuse of transparency, the planning of the building to another architect.[59]

On the same day Gur wrote a letter to the members of the Implementation Committee in which he wondered how the Implementation Committee should act with regards to Karmi's plan, without mentioning a new competition.[60] But the intrigue didn't succeed. At the meeting held by the Committee on the new plan in May 1960, general satisfaction was expressed with it, and it was approved.[61] As a result Yohanan Ratner resigned, and shortly thereafter Shlomo Gur resigned as well.

Ratner and Gur were right when they argued that Dov and Ram Karmi's plan was completely different from Klarwein's original plan. Years later Ram Karmi said that he and his father did not relate to Klarwein's plan, or to Powsner's plan when they prepared their proposal, even though he himself consulted with Ze`ev Rabina, who had worked with Powsner. "The truth is that we felt sorry for Klarwein. We chopped up his building… So I said to my dad, that even though we had prepared the new plan, if we wished to create a good atmosphere, so that the plan would go through as smoothly as possible, we ought to forego mention of our name, and leave Klarwein's name".[62] It is possible that had the issue reached the courts, the Knesset would have been forced to hold a new competition, but this did not happen.

Six Years of Planning and Construction, mid-1960 to mid-1966

Towards the end of 1960 Dov Karmi proposed to the Implementation Committee that the front of the building be constructed in bare concrete, in combination with reddish Jerusalem stone, so that the building would fulfill the requirements of the municipal bylaws of Jerusalem.[63] The engineer Emanuel Friedman, who replaced Shlomo Gur as the project's coordinating manager, visited several sites abroad, including the UNESCO building in Paris, which had so impressed Klarwein two years earlier, in order to learn about the use of bare concrete. A year later, additional visits were made abroad - especially to London - for the same purpose.[64]

As to the reddish Jerusalem stone, since such stone is to be found in large quantities only in the Hebron area, which in that period was still under Jordanian rule, it was planned to bring similar stone from a quarry in Fasutta in the Galilee. In January 1962, when excavations began of the foundations for the building, red stone was found on the location in sufficient quantities, and Minister of Finance Levi Eshkol, together with the Governor of the Bank of Israel David Horowitz, approved a special budget of IL 170,000 (a vast sum in those days) to excavate and cut it.[65] But finally, the idea had to be dropped, since it was necessary to blow up the stone in order to lay the foundations, and it would subsequently have been impossible to cut it.[66]

The evolution of the design of the columns surrounding the building, is a story in itself. In his original plan Klarwein planned seventy columns - twenty in front and in back, and fifteen on each side. He wished to place square columns, covered with stone or mosaic, whose main function would be aesthetic - they were planned to stand at a great distance from the building itself (at a certain stage Klarwein spoke of 7 meters[67]), and to bear a pergola, that would shade the building.[68]

In the meetings of the Implementation Committee in the course of February 1959 the columns were discussed: their height, the space between them and their shape. At this stage the space between the bases of the columns mentioned was 7-8 meters (in the final plan the space was set at 4.5 meters), and a vivid debate went on whether the columns should be square (as proposed by Klarwein), round (as proposed by Powsner) or rectangular (as proposed by Ratner).[69] In March 1959, when Klarwein and Powsner worked on their joint version of the building, Powsner explained the logic in placing the columns, or as he termed them, "the colonnade": "From a practical point of view the colonnade offers just one thing - shading around the building… From an aesthetic point of view… its advantage is that it provides the exterior of the building with a sense of unity. Without the colonnade, a problem of fenestration would emerge".[70]

According to Dov and Ram Karmi's plan, the columns were to have "opened up in all directions like concrete mushrooms".[71] However, Ram was not happy about the columns, and wanted to cancel them altogether, or reduce their number to no more than seven on each side (according to him "the eye cannot grasp more than seven columns"). But his father refused, because he had undertaken to leave the columns.[72] As a result of the argument with his father, Ram left the project, and traveled to Sierra-Leone to plan a parliament there.

Dov Karmi passed away suddenly of a heart attack in May 1962, but a representative of the Karmi family still remained on the team - the British architect William (Bill) Gillitt,[73] who had studied with Ram in London. But after a while Gillitt resigned as well, against the background of changes that Klarwein insisted on introducing into the plans after Dov's death - inter alia in the shape of the columns. In November 1962 Klarwein proposed that the columns be covered with ceramics and decorated,[74] but after he returned from a visit to France, he brought with him a plan for the columns that was finally accepted - rectangular columns, made of bare cement.[75]



The Ataturk Mausoleum in Ankara

The journalist Yehuda Ha`ezrahi described the metamorphosis which the columns underwent in the following words: “Instead of massive stone columns, intended to stand at the front of the building, shaping its image by means of their size and glory, the planners decided to decorate the section with a concrete edge, protruding to the front, and construct beneath it thin concrete columns, with an apparent double purpose, both decorative and functional, and they are constructed deep under the overhang, close to the walls, ‘tied’ to them with stump-boards, to support the internal ceilings”.[76]

In addition to the change in the shape of the columns, Klarwein also introduced changes in the ceiling of the plenary hall, and canceled the galleries planned in the State Hall.[77] Following these changes three of the well-known architects in the country at the time - Arieh Sharon, Avraham Yaski and Al Mansfeld - wrote a letter of protest to the Implementation Committee,[78] and in May 1963 the chairman of the Association of Engineers and Architects, Shmuel Mestechkin, together with Mansfeld and Yaski, met with the Speaker of the Knesset, Kadish Luz (who was also chairman of the Implementation Committee) on this matter. But the Implementation Committee, that had had enough of the wars of the architects, decided to disregard their appeal. In a last minute effort to stop Klarwein, Yaski approached him in a letter, dated August 5, 1963, in which he emphatically demanded of him to publish the plans of the Knesset building, with the changes that he had introduced after Dov Karmi’s death. “If you will not respond to our request within two weeks of the date on which this letter was sent”, he added, “we shall have no choice but to inform the general public, that the plans of the Knesset building have turned into a secret document [emphasis in the original], and that the Association of Architects - that represents the professional public - knows nothing of the state of the plans of the Knesset building”. In his reply Klarwein rejected all the claims and demands.[79]

Design of the Knesset Interior

Already in mid-1959, the possibility of inviting the architect Dora Gad, to help with the interior decoration of the Knesset building, was mentioned. She was first contacted in November 1962, but began to work, with her partner Arie Noi, only in December 1963. Gad's entry into the project was accompanied by various problems, including the fact that she did not like the building which Klarwein had designed.[80] In addition, there existed among the members of the Implementation Committee a certain ambivalence regarding the role of an interior decorator - a profession that was new in Israel in the 1960s - and on several occasions Gad found herself explaining the essence of her job to the members of the committee. The main problem which Gad perceived was "how to designate to this rigid structure and its vast and monumental spaces, a human dimension, a certain pleasantness and Israeli simplicity and modesty, and at the same time, preserve its dignity and representational character".[81] She decided to solve the problem by having few decorations, unadorned floors and wall spaces, and a limited variety of colors.

The Plenary Hall

Despite Klarwein's original objection, it was decided that Gad would participate in the design of the plenary hall, after various problems emerged regarding its planning. The two main problems concerned the chamber's ceiling and the wall at its front, behind the Speaker's podium. As to the ceiling, Klarwein had planned it in the shape of a vault, constructed of bare concrete, with 16 upper windows, seeking to make do with natural lighting only. His opponents argued that the ceiling was too high and creates an atmosphere of alienation in the chamber; that it would erase the effect of the wall at the front of the chamber; that the lighting would not fall evenly in the chamber; that in any event there would be need for artificial lighting after sunset; and that the height would create acoustical problems.[82] The solution that the opponents proposed was to lower the ceiling, or alternatively to add a hanging ceiling (or intermediate ceiling). Klarwein strongly opposed these solutions, while Gad insisted on the intermediate ceiling being added, and suggested a circular ceiling.



The Knesset plenum (November 21, 1988). The "guillotines" can be seen clearly above the gallery.

Among the experts brought to express their opinion on this matter some supported Klarwein and some supported Gad,[83] but the Implementation Committee was impressed in particular by the comments of the Haifa architect Shmuel Rosoff: "Since it is necessary that in the Knesset plenary hall there will be a serene and balanced atmosphere, the existing ceiling, being an extraordinary and dynamic structure that catches the eye, is liable to be a factor that disturbs the creation of a quiet atmosphere in the hall, and it is therefore necessary to find a way to 'calm' the ceiling down, and make it less dominant. This can be achieved by hanging a ceiling under the existing roof".[84] The interior architect Rafi Bloomfeld, who was brought at Klarwein's request to help in the planning of the plenary hall, after differences of opinion emerged between himself and Gad, supported the idea of a hanging ceiling.

The hanging ceiling was finally designed by the sculptor Danny Karavan, who also constructed the wall at the front of the chamber (see below). In the beginning Karavan proposed that under the vault a "net-like metal structure be installed, so that the light coming through it would be in the shape of tents with vertical lines, symbolizing the desert, and with horizontal lines, symbolizing a Star of David".[85] But this proposal was rejected, and it was decided to install a hanging ceiling, made up of twelve wooden planks (nicknamed 'the guillotines') painted white, the weight of each of them being 200 kg. Klarwein, who described the ceiling as "abominable", and argued that the ceiling constitutes a "mortal danger", since the planks were liable, Heaven forbid, to fall.[86] Furthermore, the members of the Knesset House Committee, who visited the plenary hall after the "guillotines" were put up, were shocked and demanded that they be removed.[87] But the ceiling remained, and today there is hardly anyone who pays attention to its existence. As to the lighting, most of the windows in the vault were painted black, and projectors were placed behind glass, facing downwards.[88]

Originally, Klarwein proposed that the wall at the front of the hall behind the Speaker's podium, be overlain with wood, and decorated with a candelabrum made of shining copper, with the symbols of the tribes, and Herzl's picture in the form of a relief.[89] Later he proposed that the wall be covered with marble, with a relief of Herzl made in silver, bronze or copper, and that the wall be divided by a vertical line. However, a totally different concept was approved by the Implementation Committee, based on a proposal made by Gad.



The podium in the plenary hall, and the wall designed by Danny Karavan

Gad approached the sculptor Danny Karavan about designing the wall, and he planned a stone wall, the subject of which was the connection between the celestial, spiritual Jerusalem, and the earthly, material Jerusalem. The wall, constructed of light okra colored Galilean chalk stone, from Dir-el-Asad, is thirty meters long and 7.5 meters high, and it is constructed of stones that are approximately 2X1 meters in size and 20-30 cm thick. The stones were cut by Jerusalem stonecutters, under the instructions of the artist, who got to know the personal style of each of them, and instructed him accordingly. Every stone was designed individually and stands on its own. The work on the wall was performed outside the building in the shade, and went on for eight months. Karavan sought to design a work of art of visual significance, which would be pleasant to the eye and uncomplicated, befitting a wall that is to serve as a background to those sitting on the Knesset podium and the speakers.[90]

Due to the demand of the Knesset administration that a portrait of Herzl appear on the wall, Karavan considered engraving his image in stone. But this plan did not materialize, and the portrait that was placed on the left side of the wall, is cauterized on a dark zinc board. One of the proposals raised in the deliberations of the Implementation Committee was that the wall be decorated with phrases from the Bible. Again, Klarwein objected,[91] but it was finally Karavan, who convinced the Committee to give the idea up on aesthetic grounds. Another idea that was rejected was to construct a seat for the President of the State in a small veranda extending from the wall. At Karavan's request it was finally decided that the President would

sit in a less exposed location - on the right side of the visitors' gallery. Karavan had argued that if the President would sit in the wall, he would look like "some sort of Cuckoo clock", and every time he scratched his nose or fell asleep, the whole world would be able to see it.[92]

In the competition program it was stipulated that there should be two galleries in the plenary hall: the lower one for important guests and for the media, and above it a gallery for the general public. The original idea was to connect the lower gallery to the area in the Chamber where the Members sit by means of a staircase, but this idea too was soon disbanded.[93] The architect Ze`ev Rabina, who was involved in the planning of the plenary hall in its early stages, explained that the angle at which the lower gallery was constructed in relation to the hall, gives those sitting in it the feeling that they are close to the Representatives sitting below, while the Members of the Knesset feel separated from those sitting in the gallery.[94] For security reasons it was decided to separate the upper gallery from the hall by means of bulletproof glass, and this after a demented person had thrown a hand grenade into the plenary hall in the Knesset ,on October 29, 1957, when it was still sitting in the Frumin building. On that occasion Prime Minister David Ben Gurion, and several other Ministers were wounded. Ex Post Facto there were complaints that the glass made the upper gallery look like an aquarium.[95]

An additional problem in the planning of the plenary hall concerned the seats for Members of the Knesset. At first, before Gad had joined the planning team, it was proposed that there should be 200 seats, in order to prepare for the possibility that the number of MKs would increase should the electoral system be reformed. In December 1964 Gad and her partner Noi presented a plan that included 123 seats, with the possibility of increasing the number to 146. Finally it was decided to have 116 seats for MKs, in addition to the seats around the Government table. The options examined for seats included benches, such as those in the British House of Commons, moveable chairs, and chairs that are attached to the floor. Gad chose the latter option, due to the slanting floor.[96] The seats are arranged in the form of a ten branched candelabrum, with the Government table, shaped like a horseshoe, constitutes the two center branches. There is a minor curiosity connected with the Government table. On February 13, 1963, Prime Minister Ben Gurion wrote a letter to the Speaker of the Knesset, Kadish Luz, in which he argued that the special Government table should be cancelled, since it is, in his opinion, distasteful. He preferred the British tradition, according to which the members of the Government and the heads of the Opposition sit opposite each other on the front benches of the Chamber.[97] Ben Gurion's proposal wasn't even raised for deliberation in the Implementation Committee.

The State Hall

The design of the State Hall, planned for State events and receptions, also received much attention. In the plan presented by Powsner and Klarwein in June 1959, the State Hall, the Members' restaurant and the general cafeteria were to have opened to an inner courtyard.[98] However, the courtyard was finally cancelled. According to the final plan, the hall was to be the first large space one would arrive at after entering the building through an entrance with a relatively low ceiling. Some criticized this concept, while others justified it. The latter explained that in the temples of various cultures, the entrance was frequently by means of low and narrow passageways.[99]



Reception held by Menachem Begin for U.S. President Jimmy Carter in the Chagall Hall (March 12, 1979)

In 1960 the Speaker of the Knesset, Kadish Luz, asked the artist Marc Chagall, whether he would be willing to decorate the State Hall.[100] At first the idea was to have stainless-glass windows, such as those that Chagall had designed several years earlier for the synagogue in the Hadassah hospital at Ein Karem, or murals. Chagall proposed tapestries,[101] even though he had never engaged in this form of art, and it was not easy to translate his style of painting into tapestry stitches. After the Knesset accepted the idea, Chagall proposed that the themes for the tapestries should be: "At the end of times"; "Moses, King David and the Diaspora", and the "Reemergence of the State of Israel". Luz provided Chagall with phrases from the Old Testament connected with these themes, and many of the motifs in the tapestries are based on those phrases.[102]



The Chagall Hall: Chagall's tapestries and the "chocolate bar" ceiling

At around the same time as Gad started to work as the interior decorator of the building, Luz promised Chagall that nothing would be done in the State Hall without his consent regarding the lighting, floor, ceiling, colors and curtains, and this promise was kept. Chagall was also the one who chose the option of covering the ceiling of the Hall with 100,000 wooden cubes (the alternative, proposed by Gad, was aluminum cubes). Klarwein, who stated that the ceiling looked like a "advertisement for chocolate", was not happy with this solution.[103]



The ceiling of the Chagall Hall, and the Ben-Shmuel relief

In July 1964, it was agreed with Chagall that the floor in the State Hall would not be covered with a wall to wall carpet, made of polished stone. Chagall proposed that twelve asymmetrical mosaics, depicting traditional motifs appearing in mosaics found in ancient synagogues in the country from the sixth and seventhes centuries C.E., be set in the floor. Klarwein's comment was that this made the floor look like a "golf course".[104] In December 1965 Chagall also decided to add a wall mosaic, representing the phrase from the Book of Psalms: "On the River of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion… If I forget thee, O Jerusalem, let my right hand forget her cunning…" (137:1&6). After concluding that there were no mosaic makers in Israel capable of performing the job to his satisfaction, Chagall sent for his favorite mosaic artists - the Melano couple from Paris, and they came to Jerusalem to do the job.[105]

There was only one request made by Chagall on which Klarwein refused to yield: "When he wanted me to block the windows [in the Hall] with the view, so that [the natural light] would not disturb his tapestries, I objected".[106]

The Government Meeting Room

The Government Room, which Gad designed without any outside intervention, is on the second floor of the building. The purpose of this room is that whenever necessary Government meetings, or meetings with important guests, can be held there. This room is one of the most beautiful spaces in the Knesset, even though its dimensions are small.



The Knesset House Committee room, view from the inside.



Knesset House Committee room, view from the outside. Photographer: Susan Hattis Rolef


Meeting in the Knesset Foreign Affairs and Defense Committee room (March 23, 1989)


The Knesset Constitution, Law and Justice Committee room: view from the inside

Most of the room's space is taken up by a round table, made of heavy wood. In front of every seat there is a black leather pad. Above the table there is a white round interim ceiling, to which fixtures for lighting are attached. The floor is covered with a blue carpet. The room's walls are plated with light oak wood, and on the wall facing the entrance to the room there is a large oil painting by the artist Reuven Rubin.[107]

The Committee Floor

The rooms of nine of the permanent Committees are situated on the first floor, in the terraced structure on the Southern slopes of the building. In order to somewhat soften the right angled rigidity of the internal spaces, Ram Karmi decided that the walls of the committee rooms facing the corridor, should protrude in this direction.[108]

After a proposal to separate the seats in the Committee rooms from the windows by means of a partition was rejected,[109] the windows were placed at the edge of each room at a diagonal, so that none of those sitting around the table would be seen by the others as a silhouette. According to Rabina, who participated in the planning of the rooms, this resulted in the rooms having the shape of potatoes.[110] The external walls of the Committee rooms, facing the corridor, were constructed of burnt red bricks. On the interior they were covered with Oak, and all in all, three different shades of wood were used in the Committee rooms. In every room there is a large rectangular table, made of heavy Teak. The walls of the corridor opposite the committee rooms were constructed in bare concrete, but were later painted grey.[111]

A prayer room, that was later renamed a synagogue, was also constructed on the Committee floor. The synagogue was planned by the architect David Cassuto.[112]

Rooms for Members of the Knesset

Today it is difficult to imagine the Knesset building without a personal room for each of the Member of Knesset. However, forty years ago this seemed superfluous, or at least a luxury. At a meeting with the representatives of the Ministry of Finance one of the members of the Implementation Committee, Member of the Knesset Israel Guri, stated that originally, when he had seen the plan to allot rooms for sixty percent of the Knesset Members, he had felt that this was a very good idea, but that after it was decided to cut down the dimensions of the building it was felt that the number of rooms should be reduced, "and perhaps it is possible to reduce the number even further".[113] When the issue of the rooms for Members of the Knesset came up again for deliberation in the Implementation Committee in June 1960, and it was announced that thirty rooms were to be allotted for the use of Knesset Members of the Knesset, in each of which two Knesset Members would sit, in addition to six common meetings rooms, Yitzhak Eilam, who in those days was the Director of "Koor", and a member of the Committee, argued that "this is burning away money… It is exaggerated, and cannot be!"[114] But over the years it became apparent that a mistake had been made on

this matter, and in 1982 a new wing started to be planned to the South of the existing building, in order to solve the problem of a shortage in rooms.[115]

Art

After returning from a tour of parliaments in Europe at the end of 1958, Powsner commented that during a visit to the regional parliament building in Harlem in the Netherlands, the construction of which had been completed in 1956/57, he had learnt about "the architectural difficulties in using art". In his opinion, even though the planning of the building in Harlem was very clear, there had been an exaggeration in the integration of a large quantity and variety of art works, and "the result is that the decoration came at the expense of the simple architecture".[116]



Marc Chagall supervising the creation of the center tapestry



David Palombo working on the Knesset Gates. Photographer: Werner Braun



Work on the wall mosaic by Chagall



The Knesset as seen through the Palombo Gates.

It was, however, only six years later that the issue of the integration of works of art in the Knesset building, and especially the two "jewels in the crown" - the Chagall tapestries and mosaics and Karavan's wall in the plenary hall – started to be dealt with seriously. In the Implementation Committee there was talk of establishing an expert art committee,[117] but it was finally Gad who decided, more or less on her own, which works to order and from whom.[118] Gad's main problem was the scanty budget at her disposal.[119] Gad mentioned her distress to the Speaker of the Knesset, Kadish Luz, and in a letter that she sent him on September 2, 1965, she had the following to say:

Unlike the beginning of the Century, we are returning in our age to the approach that architecture is not complete unless the two other arts are combined in it - sculpture and painting. This approach was predominant is the periods in which the good buildings were built, as in the Renaissance, the Baroque and the Gothic era, and even in the period of magnificent construction in the country in the period in which the Temple was built, in the Hellenistic period, in the Roman period, etc. In the Knesset building - the most important in our state - the need to add works of art to the various spaces in the building is self-evident, especially in view of the fact that the planning work was done with the prior thought that works of art would

enrich the place, especially spiritually, and would add to it color and interest. In most countries at least 2% of the building's budget is devoted to art… This is a minimum required to complete the Knesset building.[120]

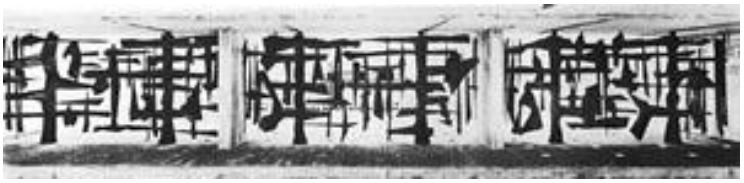
Gad also approached the then Prime Minister, Levi Eshkol, directly, and he referred her to the widow of the James de Rothschild. And indeed, Dorothy de Rothschild donated an additional sum of money for art works, most of which was used to finance Karavan's wall in the plenary hall.[121]

It was Gad who approached the sculptor David Palombo to design and create the gates to the Knesset compound. The three gates that Palombo created were made of iron and were dedicated to the memory of the Holocaust. The length of the gates is 17 meters and their height is around three meters. The lattice-work of the gates is made up of abstract shapes with a most dramatic formative rhythm. Not everyone liked the gates. Klarwein himself complained about them: "It is not pleasant to talk of this now. He (Palombo) possibly created a very nice gate, but I do not understand its symbolism. I took the Chief Architect of New Delhi to see it, and when he saw it he said: 'What, you did that? It looks like Auschwitz.'"[122]

But there were others who thought otherwise. The art critic Miriam Tal wrote about them:

The iron entrance gate by Palombo, is indeed similar in its style to the Hall of Remembrance gate at Yad Vashem - a shocking and wonderful work, but also different from it. The gate is made up of three large sections, which are similar but not identical: two central pillars, from the floor to the ceiling of the entrance structure, uphold the grill-work of the three sections. The noble vertical and horizontal shapes are moderately pointed, and constructed at straight angles, that are not rigid. These shapes raise associations with Israeli vegetation - the cypress tree, for example - as well as with ancient and modern weapons. In a simple and convincing way the idea of independence has been translated into the language of solid abstract shapes, through which the Knesset building and its foreground may be observed.[123]

Palombo also sought to create the main entrance doors to the building itself, but Gad decided to commission the sculptor Shraga Weil to do the job,[124] and he designed three doors made of wood and covered with bronze sheets, which were processed by means of acid cauterization. The panels are decorated graphically with shapes taken from the treasure of Jewish symbols from ancient times. Before his premature death in a motorcycle accident Palombo managed to create a memorial to the fallen in the War of Independence, which later turned into a monument in memory of all the fallen of the IDF. The monument represented the burning bush that was not consumed. It was made of scrap iron welded together, and standing on heavy basalt stones.[125]



The Palombo gate at the entrance to the Knesset compound



The Tribes' (Weil) Gate at the entrance to the Knesset building

Gad ordered five additional works of art. She ordered a relief portraying the High Priests's breastplates from

the sculptor Buki Schwartz. The relief, which is 3.60 meters high and 3.10 meters wide, is cast in bronze and inlaid with blocks of glass. It decorates the wall along the stairs between the second and third floors. The artist Dan Ben Shmuel also created a relief with the dimension of 3.60 X 3.10 meters. The bronze relief is made-up of square and cubic shapes. According to the artist's explanation, the consistent combination of square shapes, in complicated and varied combinations, that nevertheless maintain the regularity of the basic form, is an abstract expression in sculpted form of the wealth of political and social opinions and ideas represented in the Knesset, which are subordinated to the basic laws of the democracy. However, one can view the relief also as a sort of mould or model of a modern city, whose buildings and narrow streets meet at straight angles and create a maze. This relief stands above the southern elevators on the fourth floor.[126]

A picture painted by the artist Re`uven Rubin was ordered for the government meeting room on the second floor of the building. The painting, donated by the artist to the Knesset, portrays a mountainous scenery in the Galilee, and its size is 3.30 X 2.00 meters. A picture by the artist Moshe Kastel, entitled "a song of glory for Jerusalem" was ordered for the foyer outside the Prime Minister's room on the second floor. The size of the picture is 7.00 X 2.00 meters, and it is made of ground basalt, that was gathered from the environs of Kurazin, from which a mash was prepared, which was then pasted onto wooden boards. According to Moshe Kastel "the composition is a sort of giant red rock in the form of a pyramid, standing on the base of an ancient stone. On the rock characters from biblical times are drawn in the form of a relief, a sort of pilgrimage to Jerusalem and the Temple… On the upper part of the relief ancient Hebrew characters are drawn, like a scroll symbolizing the bravery and eternal life of Jerusalem, city of David".[127]



Reuven Rubin painting the picture for the Government meeting room in the Knesset. Israel Zafrir ©, provided by the Jerusalem Post archive



Chava Kaufman making color corrections on the tiles of the ceramic wall in the cafeteria. 1966

Dora Gad got to know the ceramics artist Chava Kaufman in the course of working with her on previous projects.[128] At Gad's request Kaufman created a ceramic wall for the general cafetaria of the Knesset, whose dimensions are 21.00 X 2.85 meters. The wall is composed of ceramic tiles made in a special technique, which enables variation in and transparency of colors. The artist chose soft colors, and the entirety is abstract and decorative. One of Kaufman's teachers from the period when she studied in Paris was the mosaic artist, who Chagall had brought to the Knesset in order to produce his mosaics - Nino Melano.

Another two works of art, which were planned but were not executed, were a tapestry by Mordechai Ardon, and a mosaic by Nahum Gutman.[129] Gad also wanted a work in enamel by the artist Vera Ronnen for the Committee floor, but this was not materialize.[130]

It should be noted that Dorothy de Rothschild, who donated the money for most of the art works, did not intervene in matters of design, except for the corner in memory of her husband and his father, the Baron Edmond de Rothschild.[131]

Critique

Not all the criticism that was heard about the Knesset building, and continue to be heard,[132] was connected to the building itself. There were those who criticized the mere concept of a government complex, within the framework of which the Knesset was built, and there were those who criticized the location of the building within the complex.

During a symposium on the subject of "the monumental building in the current century", which was organized by the architectural magazine Tvai shortly after the building was inaugurated, the participants dealt, inter alia, with these questions.[133] The editor of Tvai, Abba Elhanani, was one of those who questioned the system of complexes:

I think that from an urban point of view this solution is faulty. In principle, the system of 'complexes' does not seem good or desirable to me. Not a 'government complex', a 'university complex', a 'museum complex', etc. This is truly a lethal concept both from an urban and a social point of view. It is more desirable that every area should have its own 'Sabbath'. The fact that one places the complexes close to each other, and joins them all together into a 'magnificent neighborhood of complexes' - seems to me a mistake, which one may view as 'a long term tragedy'. What one is created is an island of beauty in a sea of the mundane, and in this way one robs the city of its pauses. One may achieve distance through the uniqueness of the public building, and sometimes one also requires physical distance. But this distance must be carefully considered and examined, in order to create distance without causing detachment.[134]

In the pamphlet published by the City Planning Section at the City Engineer Department in the Municipality of Jerusalem in 1974, one may find all the arguments of those who advocated the concentration of the government and administration offices in one place, and of those who opposed it. The advocates argued that the establishment of the State and the status of Jerusalem as a capital justify the establishment of a national governmental center in the city, which will symbolize the sovereignty of the State. They believed that it is possible to separate the old city, which is an historical and religious center, and the government complex, which symbolizes a new era of the sovereignty of the Jewish people, in a clear and absolute manner. It was also argued that distancing the complex from the city center would enable the construction of high rises, and construction in stages.

The opponents argued that in terms of the regime’s image it is not desirable to create one giant complex in which thousands of government officials are concentrated, that the establishment of government offices in the center of the city would solve a problem (which existed in the first years after the establishment of the State) of a shortage in demand for the upper floors in the building there, and that the arrival and departure of the officials to and from the complex at regular hours, would create serious traffic and parking problems.

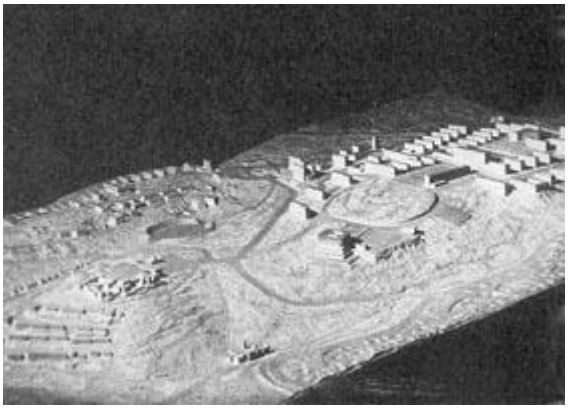
It should be noted that even the opponents did not object to the location of the Knesset building, and they agreed that "it is necessary to concentrate in the complex... all those government offices whose ties with the Knesset is especially close".[135]

On the same issue David Kroyanker wrote: "The planning of the government complex as executed, is characteristic of the planning of the typical complexes in the 1940s and the early 1950s, which is based on the concept of neighborhood units, based on the system developed in the new cities in England. This planning idea, which is not appropriate for the climatic conditions in the country, is based on a free composition of separate buildings, with large parks and roads in between".[136]

As to the location of the building in the complex, the architect David Reznik argued at the Tvai symposium:

I believe that the location of the Knesset building within the general complex of public and government buildings is based on an incorrect approach. The location of the Knesset building is a manifestation of the absence of overall planning for the whole complex. It is not feasible that one should not get a general picture of the complex of administration buildings, of which the Knesset constitutes a certain part, as a sort of crowning glory. It is true that the building stands on one of the most beautiful spaces that exist in the new

Jerusalem. But that is insufficient. This is the origin of my criticism of the building: the distance, which is created between it and the other buildings. One does not get a sense of the hierarchy here to a sufficient extent, and this is a serious shortcoming.



Model of the Government complex and the Knesset building of 1966



Aerial photograph of the Government complex in 1997

The architect Nahum Zolotov added:
There was an attempt in the Knesset building to follow the course of monumentality. But one can see that with every step taken in this direction, two steps were also taken in reverse. An attempt was made to integrate it with the buildings of the complex - but it was distanced from them for fear of a small building being swallowed up by the large office buildings. An attempt was made to achieve monumentality by locating the building at the top of a hill, but immediately there was a retreat, and it was 'divided' into small and transparent terraces. A large entrance square was created, without any frame, and from it one enters the building through three small doors which leads into a low an undefined space.

The Secretary General of the Knesset, Moshe Rossetti, who from the very beginning had supported the separation of the Knesset building from the rest of the government complex buildings, continued to support this approach:

There can be two opinions. One that the parliament should be in the midst of the government buildings, or complete separation. I am in favor of separation. One must see the Knesset as a separate function. The moment one classifies it as a governmental function, one distorts the constitution. The Knesset must stand above all the government buildings. This is correct from a parliamentary point of view. To the present, in the Frumin house, most of the people who came were passers by, and persons with nothing better to do. We feared that when we came to the new place, which is far away from the residential neighborhoods in Jerusalem, we would be isolated from visitors, and detached from the public. But we have been pleasantly surprised. Every evening there are many, who come to hear the debates in the Knesset. There is a good deal

of interest, even though the public must come specially. Nevertheless, they come. This fact makes it possible to examine whether the location has failed or not!

Neo-Classicism and the International Style

One of the harshest criticisms that were expressed against Klarwein's original plan, and the Knesset building as it was finally constructed, was that they were not Israeli. It is not clear what an 'Israeli building' is, and who is authorized to determine this. But even if one were able to reach a definition of what is 'Israeli', and decide on its basis that the Knesset is not Israeli, in this context it is worthy considering Lawrence Vale's argument in his book on the architecture of capitals, that even though parliaments are expected to represent the national identity in their style, this is usually not the case. In his words, those who decide are the leaders, and what is built represents their personal tastes and ambitions.[137] In the case of Israel, it is not the leaders who influenced the shape of the buildings, but the wars among the architects, and the compromises which enabled the truces and armistices in these wars. The compromises were frequently attained through the mediation of foreign architects and officials. The process, at the end of which the Knesset building was built as it was built, was extremely Israeli.

Nevertheless, there was someone who defended the 'Israeliness' of the building. Minister of the Interior Israel Bar Yehuda said upon the publication of the results of the competition: "the shape of the building is Israeli, because it has a flat roof. In addition, the shape of the column is not Greek, but original. There is here both great and monumental simplicity. These are two things required for the Knesset building".[138]

If one accepts the argument that the Knesset building is not an Israeli building, one may ask what it is. There are those who argue that it is neo-classical. The judges in the competition for the Knesset building, who were all Israeli officials and architects, were enthralled with the "hints of classicism" of Klarwein's model. On the other hand, many of the opponents criticized it for the very same reason. As stated above, the basic alignment of the building proposed by Klarwein - especially the two courtyards on either side of the plenary hall, and the many columns at the front of the rectangular building - reminded many of the Altes Museum constructed by Friedrich Schinkel in Berlin in the 1820s.[139]

Among the critics there were those who argued that buildings with pillars are foreign to Jerusalem, even though according to the description of the tabernacle in the Bible, which served as a basis for the planning of the Holy Temple in Jerusalem, the structure had numerous columns,[140] and in the period of the Second Temple many buildings were built in Jerusalem with columns - including the Second Temple itself, and there was a clear classical influence on the architecture.[141] Klarwein himself proposed in February 1959 that the columns should be based on the columns in the first Temple, and one of the members of the Implementation Committee of the Knesset reacted by requesting "that the characteristics of the Temple be set out in writing", for the Committee's perusal.[142]

Other critics argued that the Knesset should not look, even by insinuation, like a Greek temple. The architect Heinz Rau argued, in relating to the heavy columns proposed by Klarwein, that the building is Fascist, and represents the Nouveau Riche taste.[143] There were even some who argued that since the Nazi architect Albert Spier was considered the follower of Schinkel in the Neo-Classical style, Klarwein's building might, heaven forbid, be considered a Nazi building.[144]

Finally, the original building planned by Klarwein was unrecognizably changed, and after the construction of the building was completed, no one spoke of resemblance to Schinkel's museum, but the great resemblance (in the exterior, not in the building technique or materials) to the American Embassy in Athens (1961), planned by the father of the Bauhaus, Walter Gropius.[145] The Embassy building in Athens, which under no circumstances can be associated with the Bauhaus school, was also criticized for its Neo-Classicist hints. In his defense, Gropius could have argued that he acted in accordance with the instructions he received from the American State Department when he started planning the building in 1956: he was asked to use motifs from Greek architecture, without copying it.[146] But the columns appeared not only in the embassy in Athens, but in several additional embassies built by the United States in different countries in that period, most of which have some resemblance to the Knesset building (for example, the embassies in

Accra in Ghana, built by Harry Weese and Associates, the embassy in Baghdad, built by Joseph Louis Sert, and the embassy in New Delhi, constructed by Edward Durrell Stone). What all these buildings have in common is possible to attribute them to the late 'International Style'.[147] The architects who built in this style dealt a lot with social construction (in other words, especially housing projects), and one of their problems was that they did not manage to find original solutions for monumental buildings, and kept returning to the "good old recipes from past experience", in other words: pillars.[148]

General Criticism

After the construction work was completed, an admirer of the exterior of Knesset building said about it: "The contrasts in shape between the vertical and horizontal architectural components, are intended to increase the sense of serenity and power also manifested in the ‘civic glory of the front, which despite its monumentality preserves its human dimensions".[149]

But there were those who complained about a lack of harmony in the building, which resulted from the large number of hands that had been involved in its planning and construction. The architect David Reznik argued at the Tvai symposium: "What is lacking in [the Knesset’s] planning is a single guiding hand, and it is possible to discern compromises among various streams, which weren’t helpful". Specifically, it was argued at the symposium that there was an aesthetic fault in the fact that the lower part of the building, the terraces, were constructed of glass, while the upper part, the square structure in the middle, was constructed of sand stone. It was also pointed out that there was a lack of coordination between the design of the exterior and of the interior. "I do not belittle the interior design", Elhanani argued, "but there is a feeling that there are two languages being spoken. The architects of the building are speaking one language and the interior designers are speaking another. On the one hand there is a space made of bare concrete, and steps made of stone - simple, healthy, clean - and suddenly there is a banister made of Mahogany, and upholstery in pastel colors".



The Knesset building before its completion, in October 1964

Among the dozens of articles written in August 1966 on the Knesset building, that written by Yehuda Ha`ezrahi summed up the debate in the most comprehensive manner. "On the whole [the critics] accused the Knesset building of being excessively glorious, on the verge of exhibitionism, of lack of humility, of an over abundance of expensive decorations, of monumentality which is unbecoming a small and poor country like ours, and of being isolated and detached from the reality of the Israeli reality and of the Israeli public... There are those who called it 'an isolated fortress'. Some declared its image to be a symbol of a dictatorial regime. An undemocratic building, heaven forbid". On the there hand, Ha`ezrahi wrote, there were those who argued that "the Knesset building must constitute a well fashioned and tangible image, for the hope of divergence from the mundane, for towering above what is deserted and standard, for the aspiration for the beautiful and even the sublime... Democracy does not need to be constant belittlement, a declaration based on the lowest common denominator, but on the contrary, a constant attempt to achieve elevation and exhilaration".

But Ha'ezrahi also had his own criticism: "The failure of the Knesset building is not in its being too exhibitionist, too adorned and monumental, lacking in humility, isolated and proud, 'undemocratic' etc... Its failure is in the fact that from the very beginning, according to its basic planning, it did not diverge sufficiently from the routine of the architectural style common among us... One cannot perceive of any attempt to diverge from the track of the 'correct' architectural style - an attempt that would involve taking risks, which might lead to a bumpy road of artificiality, pretentiousness, forgery, pseudo-orientalism, and pseudo-romanticism, and dozen other types of 'pseudo', but at the same time has in it something that is able to break through the mediocrity, towards the sublime, whose aesthetic achievements are the only real achievements... The qualities of beauty, which were apparent in the Knesset building in its original planning, in so far that they were apparent, did not diverge from the defined and modest framework of what was 'safe'. This is its advantage, as well as its shortcomings... The Knesset building, as it was actually constructed, and as it appears today to the eyes of the beholder, is very different from the original plan for its construction... Finally, a building was constructed, which has no uniform creative spirit, and it emerges, even at first sight, as an unfortunate combination of different, and possibly conflicting ideas. It is not a harmonic unity, but a Sha'atnez (a mixture of things that should not be together).[150]

A Final Word

Thirty three years went by from the time that the Knesset building was inaugurated, and the writing of this article, and there are still those who like the building - including the writer of this article - which despite its shortcomings has fulfilled its designation successfully, and those who think that it is the greatest missed opportunity of Israeli architecture - a banal and confused building.

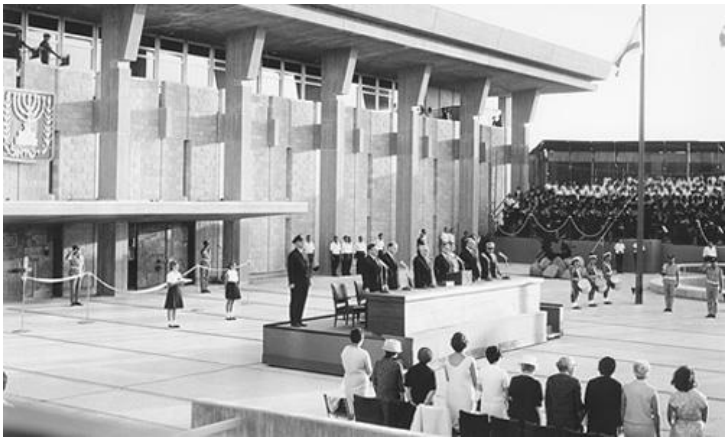


The Knesset building. 1966

The question whether one should ascribe the building to Joseph Klarwein, or to others, has also remained open. Ram Karmi himself argues that "what one sees today is exactly what I planned then", in other words, in the years 1960-61, when at his father's request he worked with Klarwein in his office.[151] At any rate, it is clear that one cannot view Klarwein as the only one responsible for the building.

Since the building was inaugurated in 1966, a new wing was added, and a substantial addition is being constructed. In the summer of 1998, and after, extensive renovations were performed in the building. These have included the replacement of part of the floors on the second and third floor, which used to be covered with wall to wall carpeting or linoleum, with shining marble, and significant changes in the ceiling of the plenary hall, so that it is now almost impossible to see the high ceiling planned by Klarwein through the "guillotines".

One fact cannot be ignored, and it is that the story of the planning of the building, and its construction - a process that lasted for over ten years - is extremely passionate and very Israeli. Many energies, both positive and negative, were invested in it. But despite everything, the building was constructed and completed, and the democratic life of the State of Israel has been pursued in it in a regular and orderly manner



The inauguration of the Knesset building (August 30, 1966)

The Knesset Building: Additions

Originally published in Cathedra Magazine, 105th Edition, September 2002

Written by Dr. Susan Hattis Rolef

Introduction

Following the publication of the article "The Knesset Building in Givat Ram: Planning and Construction",[152] additional information was received, and several corrections made on the issue. The additional information was received from William (Bill) Gillitt, a British architect and a university friend of architect Ram Karmi, who took part in the planning of the Knesset building in the years 1960-62;[153] from Hans Ruegg, a Swiss architect who worked with Klarwein in 1960, and was then employed by Ma'atz on the detailed plans of the Knesset building in the years 1961-84;[154] and the engineer Eliezer Segal, a Solel Boneh old age pensioner, who was employed as the works manager of the Knesset construction project in the years 1960-66. [155]



The U.S. Embassy building in Athens, planned by Walter Gropius

In addition to the interviews with these persons, several albums of photographs were received from Gillitt. Some of the photos were taken by Gillitt at the building site, and others are of plans and models, which he had prepared in the years 1960-62. Most of the models were of the early plans for he plenary hall, of the Chagall hall, and for the external walls and columns of the building. Gillitt also presented several photographs, which Ruegg had taken at the building site in 1963, at the back of which Ruegg had written Gillitt a letter, and an eight millimeter film, which he had shot on the site. Segal offered several photographs that he had taken after the construction of the building had been completed, including color photographs from the original interior design by Dora Gad, of the Speaker's office, and the closed section in the Members' dining room.

The Plan Presented by Dov Karmi to the Implementation Committee in March 1960

Bill Gillitt spoke about the plan presented by Dov Karmi to the implementation Committee in March 1960, which had angered Shlomo Gur and Yohanan Rathner.[156] This plan, he explained, had resulted from two weeks of non-stop work by Ram Karmi and himself. They had not used any of the previous plans, but had been given the program prepared for the competition, which had taken place in the years 1956-57. He clearly remembered that one of the instructions was that the building should be surrounded by a colonnade. He denied that either he or Ram Karmi were consciously influenced in the preparation of their program by Gropius's American Embassy building in Athens,[157] or any other building.



The first model of the Knesset building by Karmi and Gillitt, 1960

The Work of Gillitt and Ruegg

After the plan prepared by Ram Karmi and Gillitt was accepted, Gillitt was appointed coordinating architect of the project, and was employed by Ma'atz.[158] Until the death of Dov Karmi, Gillitt worked together with a team of around eight persons in an office situated in a structure that was about 100 meters away from the building site.[1589] At every stage of the planning he brought the plans for the approval of Dov Karmi and Klarwein, and received from them new ideas and feed back from them. He had many differences of opinion with Klarwein, who according to him, constantly tried to revert to his original plan. Karmi usually acted as a mediator. Gillitt continued to work on the project after Karmi's sudden death in May 1962. According to him, Emanuel Friedman, the Ma'atz engineer, who was responsible for the execution of the plan, asked him whether in his opinion it was necessary to bring a replacement for Karmi, and his answer had been that it was not necessary, because the basic planning had more or less been completed.

According to Gillitt, the method of work on the Knesset building project was what is known today as "fast-track", in other words, there is no complete work plan before the construction begins, and at every stage work plans are prepared for the next stage of the project, and passed on to the builders. So, for example, on a series of photographs that he sent to Gillitt on May 8, 1963, Ruegg noted that preparations for the protruding roof of the building was in about to begin, even though it was still not clear what height the roof would be. The engineer Eliezer Segal noted that this method of work, and the frequent changes put into the plans, served the interests of Solel Boneh well. He commented that in order to win this prestigious project Solel Boneh had bid a low price in the tender, and if it hadn't been for all the changes in the plan, the construction company would have lost a lot of money.



The Knesset building site in 1961 looking southwards, with two giant cranes, and the track on which they moved. Photographer: Bill Gillitt

Ruegg joined the project in the summer of 1961, more than a year before Gillitt left. Like Gillitt he also claimed that the general plans for the building had been more or less completed before Dov Karmi's death.[160] Nevertheless, according to him at the end of 1962 there were still several serious basic contradictions in the plans, especially regarding the roof. (See bellow) At this stage, he added, the only thing that remained of Klarwein's original plan was the basic idea of "a classic structure at the top of a hill". Regarding the plan prepared by Ram Karmi and Gillitt (which he attributed primarily to Karmi) he claimed that the “a classical building was placed on levels of glass" was peculiar.

Ruegg's feelings about Klarwein were mixed. After having worked with him for almost a year Ruegg had decided to leave him, it was difficult to get on with “the old crocodile". Why did he choose to call Klarwein an old crocodile? "He was very tough with people, but he was a type who could feel terribly sorry for himself", Ruegg replied in Hebrew. Even though he claimed to have learnt nothing professionally from Klarwein, Ruegg did learn from him one "how to present a plan for the contractor on a single page". Ruegg remained with the project until the end of 1964, and he had some interesting comments to make regarding progress in the planning and construction. In the second half of

1962 and in the course of 1963, Klarwein had introduced several significant changes in the plans left by Dov Karmi, and Ruegg, like Gillitt until he left, did everything in his power to obstruct these intentions. He was especially angry with Ram Karmi for preferring to concentrate on fighting the Knesset over a financial claim than on defending his own plans. Ruegg describes the year 1964 as the year in which "Klarwein and Dora Gad devoured each other", which was the main reason for his own decision to leave the project, and return to Switzerland.



Work on the Knesset building before the roof was cast.
Photographer: Hans Ruegg

The Changes Introduced by Klarwein in the Knesset Plan After May 1962

The main changes introduced by Klarwein in the plans after May 1962 were in the plenary hall, the state hall (the Chagall hall), the external columns and the roof. Among the photographs received from Gillitt there are a few of models of these elements before Klarwein's changes. In the last resort Klarwein got his way with regards to the columns and roof, succeeded only partially in the Chagall hall, and even though he managed to cancel the original plan for the plenary hall, it was not his plan, but Dora Gad's plan that was finally realized.[161]

The Plenary Hall

The original plan for the plenary hall, in the preparation of which Jerusalem architect Ze`ev Rabina had participated,[162] and a model of which was prepared by Gillitt (See photograph), included a hanging ceiling, a small balcony on the left side of the front wall for the President, seats for the Members of the Knesset separated by many passages, and one long Government table in the middle, similar to the one that had been situated in the old Knesset plenary hall in the Flumin building (See photograph). The plan also foresaw a single gallery, without a separation between important guests and the general public.



A model of the original plan for the plenary hall, with the President’s balcony on the left. Photographer: Bill Gillitt



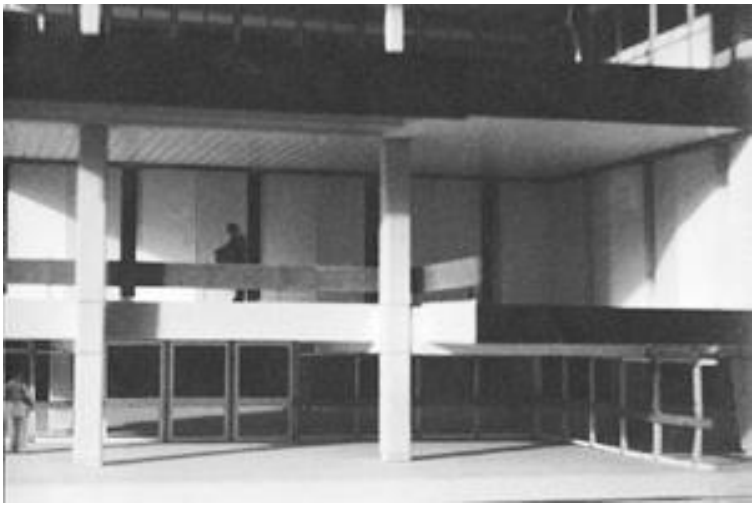
A model of the original plan for the plenary hall: a view in the direction of the galleries, without a partition, and with hanging ceiling. Photographer: Bill Gillitt

Klarwein did away with the hanging ceiling, to which he referred in contempt as "interior architecture", and he decided that the ceiling should be constructed of bare concrete.[163] According to Ruegg, this created a problem because "how can one place a single ceiling on a shape that is to polygonal, like this hall? Klarwein created a vault up above, and wanted it to remain open. He also planned, lower down, another level of horizontal cement, in order to get the wall to end somewhere. But the acoustics were terrible". Finally, this plan was not adopted, and after Dora Gad entered the picture, the hanging ceiling was returned, but in a different shape than that originally foreseen.[164] The balcony for the President was cancelled because Danny Karavan, who planned the front wall of the plenary hall, objected.[165] Gad made changes regarding the furniture for the plenary hall, and the important visitors' gallery was separated from that for the general public by means of bulletproof glass, for security reasons.

In the original article it was pointed out that at an early stage it had been suggested that the front wall in the plenary hall be adorned with phrases from the bible.[166] It transpires that before the idea was finally discarded several experiments were made to cut words in stone in various styles. The stones on which the words were cut ended up in Segal's back yard in the Beit Hakerem neighborhood of Jerusalem.

The Gallery in the Chagall Hall

The original plan for the state hall included a gallery, that was to have surrounded the wall opposite the Chagall tapestries, and the wall facing South (See photograph).



A model of the gallery for visitors, planned for the Chagall Hall.
Photographer: Bill Gillitt

From the point where there are several stairs going down from the level of the main entrance into the Chagall hall, there should have been stairs going up to the gallery. The three to four meter wide gallery, was to have been built above the line of the windows in the state hall, and join the upper part of the plenary hall, at the point where the President's balcony had been planned. In the gallery itself sitting corners, and meeting spaces were planned for Members of the Knesset and their guests. In addition to the practical function of offering comfortable seating arrangements for the Members and their guests, the gallery also had an aesthetic function - to break the strong light that enters through the halls' windows, and is reflected back from the marble floor.[167] Klarwein, who liked high ceilings and natural lighting (which was why he had sought to cancel the hanging ceiling in the plenary hall), decided at the beginning of 1963 to cancel the gallery in the state hall. According to Ruegg, this also resulted from the fact that the function of the meeting place was not clear. Since no special area had been allocated for Members' meetings with their guests, and, as noted above, no personal rooms had been planned for the Members, once the building was inaugurated the Members' dining room soon turned into the preferred meeting place.

The Roof and the External Columns

According to the original plan, as it was formulated in 1961, the external columns, which support the roof, were to have been rectangular, widening inwards between two links to the external wall, and then growing narrow again as they approached the roof. The connection of the columns with the roof was in the form of upside-down pyramids - not of mushrooms, as Ram Karmi had claimed in his interview with the author.[168]

In the new plan, which Klarwein completed after Gillitt's departure, the rectangular columns remained straight for three quarters of the way upwards, and widen outwards only in their upper part. (See photograph)



A model of the columns as originally Planned. Photographer: Bill Gillitt

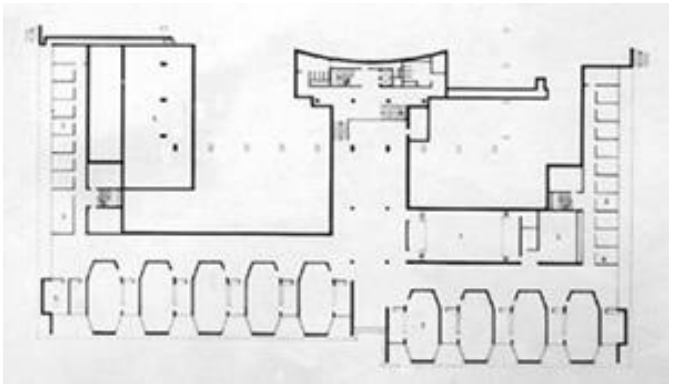


The external wall with the columns, as constructed

Klarwein added another layer of cement to the roof, and cut down the protrusion of the roof. In the original plan the roof was to have protruded by two meters,[169] and thus created shading. The lower links of the columns to the walls were to have continued into the building on its Western and Southern sides, as support boards for the gallery floor in the state hall. (See photograph) Both Ruegg and Segal mentioned that the outer walls of the building, between the fourth and fifth floors, which are covered with red stone (Mizi Yehudi Malwan), actually hang on the columns, and do not rest on the ceiling of the third floor (the floor of the fourth floor). As to the stone, with which the outer walls of the building are covered, even though approval was given to use the stone found in the foundations,[170] finally the stone was brought from the Galilee, because in order to prepare the ground for the building's foundations it was necessary to blow up the stone on the locations, and was no longer possible to cut it.[171]

Additional Comments Regarding the Planning of the Knesset Building

With regards to the planning of the Committee rooms, Gillitt added further insights to what Ze`ev Rabina had said regarding the direction of the windows.[172] Gillitt said that the external windows of the Committee rooms were constructed at an angle primarily because the Southern wall, which faced the Jordanian armed position, was planned as a security wall, and it was considered dangerous to have the windows facing directly to the South. In photographs of the plan for the Committee floor provided by Gillitt, one can see clearly that the rooms are shaped like potatoes, as described by Rabina. (See photograph)



The architectural plan for the Committee floor, 1962

Gillitt pointed out that he had planned the Knesset library, with the depression in the center known as “the pool”, under the inspiration of the library constructed by the Finnish architect Alvar Alto in the Finnish town of Viipuri in the years 1927-1935.[173] There are several other architectural elements in the Knesset building that are reminiscent of Alto’s work (see photographs).

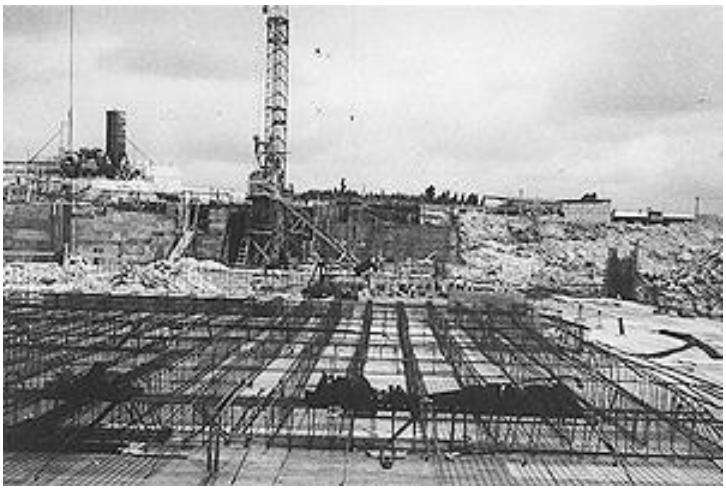


The “pool” of the library reading hall, whose design was influenced by Alvar Alto’s library in Viipuri (inset)

As to the foreground in front of the building, in Karmi and Gillitt’s plan from 1960 no fence was planned in front, and the descent from the foreground was to have been by means of a ramp, leading towards a parking lot, or a bridge above the entrance road. According to Ruegg, in 1964 Klarwein presented a plan for the foreground (in his words the “square”) which seemed to him like a “Mussolini show. When he came with this plan for the square I said to him: ‘Mr. Klarwein, forgive me, but this is Fascist architecture’… He was very insulted”. Finally the plan for the foreground was softened, and lawns were added to it.

The Construction Work

The work manager at the Knesset site, the engineer Eliezer Segal, added many details regarding the construction process itself. In the beginning of the 1960s, he related, there were still no cement factories in the country, and the technology of cement pumps didn't exist. Therefore, a small plant for the manufacture of cement was established on the Northern side of the site, on a small hill. Mrs. Tsidon-Friedland, director of the Construction Materials Department in the Technion was in charge of the quality of the cement, and a special technician, who slept on the site, was sent to supervise the production.



The Knesset building site. The cement factory is on the left.

In order to facilitate the construction work, two vast cranes - the largest available in Israel at the time - were brought to the site, and these moved on broad rails: one on the higher Northern side of the structure, and the other from the middle of the Western side, through the Southern side, and up to the middle of the Eastern side. (See photograph) Until the completion of the first floor - the Committee floor - the lower, Southern rail entered into the center of the structure. Inter alia the cranes were used to fill the large hollows on the Committee floor, and part of the second floor - the Government floor - with gravel and soil. Over the filled hollows, a floor made of fortified concrete was cast.

Segal's view of Klarwein is different from that of Gillitt and Ruegg. He noted that Klarwein was a very decent man, and a talented architect. He felt sorry for him because "I saw how he was being 'raped'. He was forced to do things that he didn't like".

Dora Gad's Interior Design

From slides taken by Segal soon after the construction work was completed, one can view the space of the Chagall hall before the tapestries were hung in them, and the space of the general cafeteria after the ceramic wall created by the artist Chava Kaufman, but before the tables and chairs were brought in.[174]

The style of the furniture introduced by Gad into the building may be seen in the photographs taken by Segal in the Speaker's bureau, and in the closed section of the Members' dining room. The furniture in the Speaker's bureau has been changed in the meantime several times, as has the furniture in the cafeteria (See photographs).



Meeting corner in the Knesset Speaker's bureau, designed by Dora Gad. Photographer: Eliezer Segal



The inner dining room for MKs, designed by Dora Gad. Photographer: Eliezer Segal

---

[1] Theodor Herzl, *Old-New Land*, translated by Paula Arnold, Haifa, Haifa Publishing Company Ltd., 1960, pp. 206-7.
[2] Boris Schatz, *Yerushalam Habnuya - Halom Behakitz* (*Built Jerusalem - A Daytime Dream*), Jerusalem, 1924, p. 10 (Hebrew).
[3] Tom Segev, *Yemei Hakalaniyot* (*Days of the Anemones*), Jerusalem, Keter, 1999, footnote on p. 167 (Hebrew).
[4] My sincere thanks to the architect, and chronologist of the architectural history of Jerusalem, David Kroyanker, who drew my attention to the quotes by Herzl and Schatz.
[5] The architect Heinz Rau prepared the first comprehensive plan for Jerusalem, according to which the city should be built in the shape of a horse-shoe around the "capitol" in the Western part of the city, close to the road leading to the coastal plain. (See Talia Margalit, "Bonim Le`om" [Building a Nation], *Ha'aretz*, April 23, 1999). The choice of this site for the construction of the Government complex was due to several reasons, including the fact that the area was very sparsely built, the convenient topographical structure, and the relative distance from the border with Jordan.
[6] The Planning Section was a national planning body, which at first formed part of the Ministry of Labor and Construction, was then moved to the Prime Minister's Office, and finally, in 1951, to the Ministry of the Interior. (See Abba Elhanani, *Hama`avak Le'atzma`ut Shel Ha`adrichalut Hayisra`elit Bame`ah Ha'esrim* [*The Struggle for Independence of Israeli Architecture in the 20th Century*], Tel Aviv, the Ministry of Defense Publishing House, 1998, p. 255, footnote 50). Sharon described the Section's doctrine in his book *Tichnun Physi Beyisra'el* (Physical Planning in Israel), Jerusalem, the Government Press, 1951, pp. 64-67.
[7] The State Archive, a map in envelope No. 6, file 1725, box C 5448/19.
[8] The Jerusalem municipality, Department of the City Engineer, Town Planning Section, *Kiryat Hamemshala - Kiryat Ben Gurion* (The Government Complex - the Ben-Gurion Complex), June 1974, p. 6.
[9] The State Archive, file 1719, box C 5448/13.
[10] The plan appears in the book of David Kroyanker, *Adrichalut Birushalayim: Habniya Hamodernit Mihutz Lahomot 1948-1990* (Architecture in Jerusalem: Modern construction Outside the Walls, 1948-1990), Jerusalem, the Keter Publishing House, 1991, p, 98.
[11] The State Archive, file 1719, box C 5448/13.
[12] The State Archive, file 1719a, minutes of the Government Complex Committee, box C 5448/13. It should be noted that finally neither this plan, nor any other comprehensive plan was implemented. Mordechai Shoshani, the chief architect of Ma'atz wrote the following at the end of the 1970s: "Over time it was decided that a government complex would be constructed on the site, which would include most of the

Ministries on the national level; three government buildings were constructed. They were 'sown' in the area, as thousands of housing projects were sown in the country; lands were handed over to many bodies - the Knesset, Beit Hakhayal, Yad Labanim, Binyanei Ha`uma, the Hilton Hotel, the Bank of Israel, the Archeology Institute, the stadium and the Israel Museum. Several master plans were prepared, and dust covered all of them". (Avimar Gil and Mordechai Shoshani, *Kiryat Ben Gurion, Yerushalyim* (The Ben Gurion Complex, Jerusalem), Jerusalem, 1978, p. 1)

[13] The State Archive, File 1722, Box C 5448/16.

[14] Minutes of the 48th meeting of the Complex Committee, held on May 13, 1950, the Knesset Archive, file 218, box 9.

[15] Ibid. Had the leaders of the state decided to wait for the completion of the constitution before starting to plan the Knesset building, the Knesset would not have been constructed to the present day. In any event, it should be noted that "Basic Law: the Knesset", which, like the rest of the basic laws, will eventually constitute part of Israel's Constitution, was the first basic law passed by the Knesset, on February 12, 1958, around six years after the said meeting took place.

[16] The Knesset archive, ibid.

[17] A document without a date entitled "guidelines for the drafting of the announcement of the Speaker of the Knesset, concerning the construction of the Knesset building". The Knesset Archive, File 2181, Box 9.

[18] The Secretary of the Complex Bureau, Z. Vantik, to the Secretary General of the Knesset, Moshe Rosseti, July 13, 1952. The Knesset Archive, file 218, box 9.

[19] Letter from Yerahmiel Belkind (the Knesset Serjeant at Arms until 1953) to M. Zagagi (the Ministry of Finance). The issue came up for deliberation in June 1953. The Knesset Archive, ibid.

[20] The Knesset Archive, file 2181, box 9.

[21] The Knesset Speaker, Joseph Sprinzak, announced this at a meeting that took place in his bureau on February 15, 1955. See the Knesset Archive, File 218, Box 9.

[22] Minutes of the second meeting of the Program Committee, held on March 29, 1955, Ibid.

[23] *The Knesset Record*, Volume XVIII, p. 2183, June 30, 1955.

[24] Undated press release, the Knesset Archive, file 2181, box 9.

[25] In fact, the Knesset Members almost completely avoided any involvement in the planning of the building, at all stages. On the other hand, a debate took place on whether it was proper to call the Knesset building 'mishkan' (in the Old Testament the word mishkan means 'tabernacle'. In Modern Hebrew the word means dwelling-place, or building). In the first sitting that took place in the new building on the morrow of its inauguration, at which the first reading of Basic Law: the Government was debated, MK Menachem Begin argued: "Let us not use the term mishkan. There are names in the history of the Jews that should be left untouched, because of their sanctity, or the sanctity of their uniqueness". (See, the *Knesset Record*, Volume 46, p. 2505, August 31, 1966). MK Shlomo Lorentz (from Agudat Yisrael) added: "In the name of the haredi Judaism I must comment that in our opinion the name 'mishkan haknesset' which is used to describe the new building… involves the distortion of holy values, and pretentiousness that knows no limits. The mishkan was called by that name because of the shkhina (Divine Presence) that frequently prevailed in it. When one raises the flag of secularism, and locks the gates of this House to the authority of the shkhina, there is no moral right to attach the name 'mishkan' that derives from the word shkhina, which is a term that is incomprehensible to the human mind". (Ibid. p, 2518). One of the secular MKs, who related to this comment was Israel Yeshayahu (Alignment): "I do not understand the reservations of some Members of the Knesset regarding the term mishkan. I should like to say to those religious Members… for whom every word in the Torah is holy. If we shall follow this path, we shall cease to speak Hebrew. Except for the explicit name of God, all other words in Hebrew are usable. If it were not so - where would be end? Even the word ohel (tent) will be rejected. It is written: 'ma tovu ohleicha Ya'acov, mishkenoteich Yisrael" ('How goodly are your tents, O Jacob, your swellings, Israel!' - Numbers, 24:5) - where the meaning was Yeshivot, seminaries etc. Nevertheless, there are tents (ohalim) and there are dwellings (mishkenot). Can we not use these words?… And also not the word mashkanta (mortgage)? (Ibid.. p. 2523). The word mishkan was approved and became commonplace in daily usage.

[26] The clearest proof to the fact that it was not possible to understand from the program what sort of building was perceived by those ordering it, was the lack of uniformity in the external appearance of the building as presented in the various plans submitted to the competition, even though most of them complied with the requirements of the program. The only photographs I found, which present some of the plans submitted, appeared in the *H'aolam Hazeh* weekly, August 7, 1957.

[27] In an interview with the writer on June 14, 1998, Ram Karmi said: "Someone wrote a program for the building, and one could not understand how the building was to function from the program. In a competition you do not sit with a client, but with a piece of paper. This paper said nothing".
[28] Heinz Rau, "No Hurry to Build", *The Jerusalem Post*, September 7, 1957.
[29] The background to the generous contribution was Rothschild's decision, on the eve of his death, to stop the work of the Jewish Colonization Association (originally known as PICA), to transfer all of PICA's lands to the State of Israel, and to continue to make contributions to the State (announcement of Prime Minister David Ben Gurion, *The Knesset Record*, Volume 22, p. 2475, July 22, 1957). A second contribution, to the sum of 1.17 million Israeli pounds, was transferred by Rothschild's widow, Dorothy de Rothschild, in February 1962 (announcement of the Knesset Speaker, Kadish Luz, The Knesset Record, Volume 33, p. 1211, February 12, 1962). A third contribution, to the sum of 3 million Israeli pounds, was transferred by Dorothy de Rothschild in October 1964 (announcement of the Knesset Speaker, Kadish Luz, The Knesset Record, Volume 41, p. 125, October 26, 1964). Towards the completion of the construction of the building, Dorothy contributed a fourth sum that was designated for the purchase of works of art. See below.
[30] Joseph Kalrwein (1893-1971), was born in Poland, studied architecture and art in Germany, and started his professional career there. He completed his education in the technological Institute in Munich, but did not receive a formal degree in architecture. He studied in the Master Class of Prof. Hans Poelzig in Berlin. In Hamburg he worked with Prof. Fritz Hoger. Klarwein immigrated to Palestine from Germany in 1933, and started working in Haifa. During the Second World War he moved to Jerusalem and worked in the Public Works Department of the Mandatory Administration. Inter alia, he designed "beit hakranot" on Herzl Street in Haifa, and planned the exterior of the "Dagon" silos in that city. In 1959 he was elected to the French Academy of Architecture. See, Macabee Dean, "Fighting Architect", *The Jerusalem Post*, April 8, 1960.
[31] The Central Competitions Committee of the Association of Engineers and Architects in Israel, proposed that they be appointed as members of the jury, after most of the architects whose names were originally proposed - Prof. Yohanan Ratner, Al Mansfield, Arie Sharon, Avraham Yasky, Richard Kauffmann and Uriel Schiller - preferred not to sit in the jury, in order to preserve the option of participating in the competition themselves. See the letters of the Association of Engineers and Architects in Israel, the Central Competitions Committee, to Mr. Shlomo Arazi, of August 18, 1955, and to Lieutenant Colonel Yona Hazor, of October 24, 1955, the Knesset Archive, File 2181, Box 9.
[32] Decision of the jury, July 24, 1957, the Knesset Archive, file 2183a2, box 3.
[33] Yehuda Ha`ezrahi, "Arba'im Amudei Haknesset" (The Forty Knesset Columns), *Ma'ariv*, August 26, 1966.
[34] *Ha'olam Hazeh*, August 7, 1957.
[35] *Bulletin of the Association of Engineers and Architects in Israel*, The Central Committee, 57 (October 1, 1957), kept in the Central Zionist Archive, A455/9.
[36] Knesset Archive, file 2183c, box 3.
[37] Minutes of the concluding meeting of the Special Committee for the Examination of the Knesset Building Plan, held on April 13, 1958, ibid.
[38] Klarwein had already been sent previously on a "tour of parliaments".
[39] Minutes of the 1st meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on June 23, 1958, the Knesset Archive, File 2182, Box 26.
[40] The construction of the UNESCO building in Paris, planned by the architects Marcel Breuer, Pier Luigi Nervi and Bernard Zehrfuss, was then in its final stages.
[41] Minutes of the 8th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 10, 1958, the Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 26. The UNESCO building is, of course, not a parliament, but a public building, with some features that are relevant for parliaments as well.
[42] Among Klarwein's papers we found a note, in which he wrote the following comment in English: "Competitions, I believe, are the only way for a talented architect to learn to earn a reputation and commissions, and yet remain independent of political 'favours' ". Central Zionist Archive, A455/3.
[43] Interview held by Eli Eyal with Shlomo Gur, *Ha'aretz*, March 3, 1960. About people like Gur Klarwein said: "I allways [sic.] deplore the tendency here to minimize the importance of the architect as a professional and to shift the authority and responsibility for construction to a 'building manager'", Central Zionist Archive, A455/3.
[44] The Knesset Archive, file 2182 b, box 26.

[45] Prof. Yohanan Ratner, had planned the Jewish Agency building in Jerusalem, and was head of the Faculty for Architecture in the Technion in Haifa in the years 1930-63.
[46] The secretary of the office, that was located in its early days on the top floor of the Kings Hotel in Jerusalem, was no other than Ora Teib, who was later to marry Mordechai Namir, and eventually became a Member of the Knesset and a Minister in several Governments. At the time that the office was set up Ora returned from a sojourn in New York.
[47] Minutes of the 29th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on May 13, 1959, The Knesset Archive, File 2182, Box 26. It should be noted that Ratner was not a neutral observer, but one of the representatives of the uncompromising modernism in Israeli architecture, who considered Klarwein's work to be regressive, and a disgrace to the developing national ethos. In one of the meetings of the Implementation Committee he referred to Klarwein's original plan as "a box placed in a transparent envelop of columns" (Minutes of the 19th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 24, 1959, Ibid.).
[48] Minutes of the 25th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on April 17, 1959, and Minutes of the 26th meeting, held on May 6, 1959, Ibid.
[49] In an interview with the writer on July 5, 1998, Shimon Powsner argued that despite the differences in approach between the two ("I was more modern than him") and the difference in age (Powsner was much younger), he and Klarwein had managed to find common ground on the personal level. "I managed to convince him that I am not acting against him".
[50] Very soon the idea of a round hall was given up, and the concept of a hall in the form of a trapeze was adopted. According to Klarwein, the idea of a trapeze was that of the young architects in the office, including Ze`ev Rabina. See, minutes of the 37th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 4, 1959, the Knesset Archive, File 2182, Box 26.
[51] Minutes of the 33rd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on June 22, 1959, Ibid.
[52] The State Archive, file 1719a, box C 5448/13.
[53] The debate continued over several meetings of the Implementation Committee, but the main discussion on the subject was held on March 10, 1959. See the minutes of the 21st meeting of the Implementation Committee, the Knesset Archive, File 2182, Box 26.
[54] The Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 5.
[55] Minutes of the 53rd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 29, 1960, the Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 26.
[56] Interview held by the writer with Ram Karmi on June 14, 1998.
[57] See below.
[58] Member of the Knesset Nahum Levin reported to the Implementation Committee a conversation he had had with Powsner, in which the Tel Avivian architect admitted that he found himself in the same situation in which Joseph Klarwein had found himself a year and a half previously: that his plan had been radically changed, without his being consulted. See, minutes of the 51st meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on May 24, 1960, the State Archive, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[59] The Knesset Archive, file 3181, box 25.
[60] Ibid.
[61] Minutes of the 50th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on May 8, 1960, the State Archive, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[62] Interview held by the writer with Ram Karmi on June 14, 1998.
[63] Minutes of the 55th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 3, 1960, the State Archive, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[64] Emanuel Friedman, "copy for memory", November 30, 1960, Minutes of the 63rd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on December 17, 1961, Ibid.
[65] Letter from Emanuel Friedman to Kadish Luz, July 1, 1962, the Knesset Archive, file 3180 volume b, box 25.
[66] Interview held by the writer with the work manager of "Solel Boneh" at the building site of the Knesset in the years 1960-1966, Eliezer Segal, on November 13, 2000.
[67] Minutes of the 19th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 24, 1959, the Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 26.
[68] The alignment of the columns and their shape, as described by Klarwein, resembles in many ways the mausoleum in memory of Mustafa Kemal Ataturk, founder of the Turkish republic and its first president,

which was constructed in Ankara after his death in 1938. See, Laurence J. Vale, *Architecture, Power and National Identity*, Yale University Press, New Haven and London, 1992, pp. 102-3.
[69] Minutes of the 18th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 16, 1959, the Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 26.
[70] Minutes of the 21st meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on March 10, 1959, and Minutes of the 24th meeting, held on March 17, 1959. Ibid.
[71] Interview held by the writer with Ram Karmi on June 14, 1998.
[72] In an interview with Chen Shalita, Ram Karmi described the chain of events in the following words: "When we reached the point at which it was necessary to design the front, Klarwein insisted that there should be columns around the building, even though they express nothing, in my opinion, of what is happening in the building. I was unwilling to yield and started yelling, and my father stood in the middle and said to me:'Rami, you must give in'. So I agreed that it would be like the building of the Parliament of Chandigarh in India [constructed by La Cosbusier, who Karmi calls 'my God'], which has five columns and more wall. So my father asked me to reconsider. I said:'seven columns, that is the maximum that the human eye is capable of absorbing, and still notice the number', and then my father said to me: 'you are an ass'. I was insulted, slammed the door shut, and resigned". (*Kol Ha'ir*, December 5, 1997).
[73] For information about Bill Gillitt and his work, see second article.
[74] Minutes of the 66th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 27, 1962, the State Archive, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[75] Minutes of the 70th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on January 7, 1963, ibid.
[76] Yehuda Ha'ezrahi (see above, footnote 33).
[77] Minutes of the 66th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on August 12, 1962, the State Archive, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[78] Minutes of the 68th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on October 28, 1962, ibid.
[79] Knesset Archive, files 3180 and 3181 in Box 25.
[80] In an interview with the writer, held on June 18, 1998, Gad said: "I had many arguments with Klarwein, since in my opinion he really wasn't a good architect. What he had planned was old-fashioned and classicist.
[81] Ran Shkhori, *Dora Gad - Hanochekhut Hayisraelit Be'adrichalut Pnim* (Dora Gad - the Israeli Presence in Interior Architecture), Tel Aviv, Israeli Architecture, 1997, p. 99.
[82] In her interview with the writer Gad complained that the chamber's proportions were very bad. "The chamber is in any event small, and this height (of the ceiling) further dwarfed it. But everything was finished, and I had no alternative but to work with what there was".
[83] The architect Oscar Niemeyer, the planner of the city of Brasilia, who visited the country and was invited by the Implementation Committee to express his opinion, said that both Klarwein's and Gad's proposals were reasonable, even though they emerged from different approaches. However, he added, that the final decision is usually that of the architect of the building, i.e. Klarwein. See minutes of the 84th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on June 15, 1964, the Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[84] Letter fro Shmuel Rosoff to Kadish Luz, April 26, 1964, Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[85] Minutes of the 92nd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on August 16, 1965, the Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[86] Letter from Klarwein to the Implementation Committee, July 27, 1966, Knesset Archive, file 3181, box 5, and Tamar Avidar "Ceiling of Contention", *Ma'ariv*, August 31, 1966.
[87] Minutes of the 100th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on July 18, 1966, the Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[88] In the late 1990s work was done on the ceiling, as a result of which the windows are completely blocked, and the artificial lighting was changed. Currently (2004) the removal of the "guillotines" is being considered, as part of safety measures.
[89] Minutes of the 81st meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on March 23, 1964, ibid.
[90] Interview held by the writer with Danny Karavan, May 28, 1998.
[91] In Klarwein's opinion the letters would have given the wall the image of a cemetery. See Minutes of the 74th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on July 17, 1963, the State Archive, Section 60, box 317, file 6.
[92] Interview held by the writer with Danny Karavan, May 28, 1998.
[93] Minutes of the 78th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 4, 1964, the State Archive, op. cit.

[94] Interview held by the writer with Ze`ev Rabina, on July 2, 1998.
[95] Yosef Schufman, "Parliament or Aquarium", Hayom, August 30, 1966.
[96] Minutes of the 87th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on December 15, 1964, the Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[97] Letter from Ben Gurion to Kadish Luz, February 13, 1963, the Knesset Archive, file 3181, box 25.
[98] Interview held by the wrtier with Shimon Powsner, on July 5, 1998.
[99] See debate on monumental building in the "Tvai" symposium, held on November 20, 1966, and published in full in the journal Tvai, Quarterly for Architecture, Tel Aviv, Vol. 1 No. 3, 1967, and inter view of the writer with Dora Gad, June 18, 1998.
[100] Chagall answered positively, even though a painting he had contributed to the Knesset in 1953, "Solitude", was transferred by the then Speaker, Joseph Sprinzak, to the Museum of Tel Aviv. Sprinzak had said that it was unsuitable to introduce a picture of a goat into the Knesset building. See Moshe Pomrock, *Dusk*, Tel Aviv, Otpaz Ltd. Publications, 1971, p. 104 (Hebrew) In fact it is a cow, not a goat, that appears in the painting that Chagall gave Sprinzak.
[101] Minutes of the 70th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on January 7, 1963, the State Archive, op.cit.
[102] Documents from the beginning of 1963, including letters and notes, the Knesset Archive, file 3182, the Knesset Administration, Box 2, and Moshe Pomrock (above footnote 98), pp. 110-120.
[103] "An Arrow from Silvi Keshet", *Ha'aretz*, August 26, 1966.
[104] Ibid.
[105] Minutes of the 85th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 16, 1964, the Knesset Archive, file No. 3188, box 5. In Gad's opinion the mosaic's were superfluous, but Chagall (of whom Gad told the writer that "He was antipathetic to an extent that is hard to imagine") did not accept her opinion.
[106] Keshet, see above footnote 99.
[107] Ran Shkhori, footnote No. 80.
[108] Ibid.
[109] The minutes of a meeting with the participation Ze`ev Rabina and the Deputy Secretaries General of the Knesset Clara Aran and Asher Tsidon, on August 28, 1959. The Knesset Archive, file 2181, box 9.
[110] Interview held by the writer with Ze`ev Rabina, July 2, 1998.
[111] In 2008 the Permanent Committees will all be moved to the new wing being constructed to the East of the original Knesset building. The existing committee rooms will apparently be handed over to the parliamentary groups.
[112] Knesset Speaker Kadish Luz originally insisted that the room be called a "prayer room" and not a synagogue. It was Member of the Knesset Ya'acov Hazan from Mapam, who argued that it should not be 'merely a room', but that it should contain 'religious articles'. See Minutes of the 69th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on November 27, 1962, the Knesset Archive, file No. 3188, box 5.
[113] Minutes of a joint meeting of the Implementation Committee and people from the Ministry of Finance, held on July 20, 1959, the Knesset Archive file 2182, box 26.
[114] Minutes of the 52nd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on June 21st, 1960, State Archives, section 60, box 317, file 6.
[115] The construction of the new wing, planned by Ernst Armon, the Chief Architect of the Public Works Department (Ma'atz), was completed in 1991.
[116] Minutes of the 11th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on December 1, 1958, the Knesset Archive, file 2181, box 26.
[117] It was proposed that in the Committee on Art the members would be Prof. Michael Avi Yonah, an Archeology the archeology of Eretz Yisrael, Dr. Fritz Schief, director of the Haifa museum and an expert in art history, Dora Gad and Joseph Klarwein. See minutes of the 72nd meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on March 26, 1963, the Knesset Archive, file No. 3188, box 5.
[118] There were those who objected to Dora Gad's independence on this matter. The Association of painters and sculptors, for example, sent the Speaker of the Knesset a written protest that the artists were selected without a tender. Miriam Tal, "Ha'omanut Bebinyan Haknesset" (Art in the Knesset Building), *Hayom*, October 7, 1966.
[119] It should be noted that it was the French Government that paid for Chagall's tapestries.
[120] Knesset Archive, file 3181, box 5.
[121] Interview held by the writer with Dora Gad, June 18, 1998.

[122] “Hetz Misilvy Keshet”(An Arrow from Silvi Keshet), *Ha'aretz*, August 26, 1966.
[123] Miriam Tal, “Ha'omanut Bebinyan Haknesset” (Art in the Knesset Building), *Hayom*, October 7, 1966.
[124] Minutes of the 93rd of the Implementation Committee, December 27, 1965, the Knesset Archive, file No. 3188, box 5.
[125] See guidance material on the art works in the Knesset building prepared by Avigdor Possek and Milka Chisik in October 1971, the Knesset Archive, box No. 4 (general boxes).
[126] Klarwein referred to the relief as “that ornament of strange protruding projections made by I-don’t-know-which-artist above the elevators”. “Hetz Misilvy Keshet” (An Arrow from Silvy Keshet), *Ha'aretz*, August 26, 1966.
[127] Yeshayahu Ashani, “Shir Habazelet Asher Lemoshe Kastel” (Moshe Kastel’s song of basalt), Davar, August 28, 1966.
[128] Esther Lorain, ”Kir Haharsina Baknesset" (The ceramic wall in the Knesset), *Lamerhav*, August 28, 1966.
[129] Minutes of the 96th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on March 29, 1966, and minutes of the 98th meeting of th Implementation Committee, held on June 27, 1966, the Knesset Archive, file 3188, box 5.
[130] Interview held by the writer with Dora Gad, June 18, 1998.
[131] Ibid.
[132] Much of the criticism comes from people who never bothered to examine the subject deeply, and their criticism, even if justified, is full of disinformation. See for example: Ofer Kolker, "Rega Shel Hessed - Ha`adrichalut Hayisraelit, Halom Veshivro" (A Moment of Grace - Israeli Architecture, the Dream and its Collapse) *Mifneh*, Vol. 25, No. 7, April 1999, especially the section "From Open Urban Architecture to Fortress-like, Haughty and Closed Architecture", p. 61.
[133] See above footnote 99.
[134] Similar criticism was also made regarding the administration complex built by the architect Le Corbusier in the capital of Punjab in India, Chandigarh that was inaugurated in 1951. Despite the great impression made by the buildings, that "make them effective as sculptural symbols of civic order", it is considered a functional disaster, and its isolation from the rest of the city harms the urban fabric. But that is apparently not what interested the Prime Minister of India, Juaharlal Nehru, who ordered the project and viewed it as "symbolic of the freedom of India, unfettered by the traditions of the past... an expression of the nation's faith in the future." (David Watkin, *A History of Western Architecture*, second edition, New York, Barnes & Noble books, 1996, p. 564-5. See also Lawrence J. Vale, *Architecture, Power, and National Identity*, New Haven and London, Yale University Press, pp. 105-14.
[135] The Municipality of Jerusalem (See above footnote 8), pp. 11-12.
[136] David Kroyanker (See above footnote 10), pp. 97-8.
[137] Lawrence Vale, op. cit.
[138] Minutes of the meeting, which summed up the results of the public competition for the planning of the Knesset building in Jerusalem, July 24, 1957, the Knesset Archive, file 2183 a', box 3.
[139] On Schinkel's museum see: John Zukowsky ed. *Karl Friedrich Schinkel - the Darama of Architecture*, the Art Institute of Chicago, Wasmuch, 1994, pp 145-8. Yohanan Ratner alluded to the similarity between Klarwein's plan and Schinkel's building at the meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on May 13, 1959, when he spoke of "a building from 1835" (Minutes of the 29th meeting, the Knesset Archive, file 2182, box 26). In an interview with the writer, Ram Karmi explained: "Klarwein, who came from Germany, did not belong to the side of the German Bauhaus, but to the monumental classicism of Germany. He took Schinkel's museum building in Berlin as a prototype, and put the Knesset's program into it... Both the museum building in Berlin and Klarwein's building are based on a central core, two courtyards... and at the front pillars, pillars, pillars".
[140] *Exodus*:27:9-15.
[141] See, Chaim Richman, *The House of Prayer for All Nations - the Holy Temple of Jerusalem*, Jerusalem, the Temple Institute and Carta, 1997.
[142] Minutes of the 16th meeting of the Implementation Committee, held on February 2, 1959, the Knesset Archive, file 2181, box 26. Klarwein mentioned several times over the years that in planning the Knesset building, he had been inspired by the Temple, but it appears that he did not always distinguish between the First and Second Temples.
[143] Heinz Rau, "No Hurry to Build", *The Jerusalem Post*, September 7, 1957.

[144] Ran Shchori, "Dora Gad, The Israeli Presence in Interior Design," *Architecture of Israel Quarterly*, 1997, p. 95. On this subject Klarwein's himself said, after the construction of the Knesset building was completed: "Everyone said that it is Neo-Classical and Fascist. But that is not true. It is funny. The last building I did in Berlin was in 1933. It was an Evangelical church. But I was no longer there at the inauguration, because Goring was there. Then I was besmirched by the Germans, because mosaics are foreign from a racial point of view. And here I am told that the Knesset building in Fascist..." (Silvi Keshet, op. cit.).
[145] See Michael Levin, "Adrichalut Modernit Monumentalit - Bein Yerushalayim Lebirot Ha'olam" (Monumental Modern Architecture - Between Jerusalem and the Capitals of the World), in Ora Ahimeir and Michael Levin eds. *Adrichalut Monumentalit Biyrushalyim* (Monumental Architecture in Jerusalem), Jerusalem, Carta and the Jerusalem Institute for the Study of Israel, 1984, Pp. 50-2. It is interesting that already in 1957, when the Gropius building was in its earliest stages of planning, the Jerusalem architect Ya'acov Benor-Kalter argued that such a building is justified, perhaps, in Athens, but nowhere else (Benor-Kalter, "Plan Must Reflect Needs", the *Jerusalem Post*, September 7, 1957.
[146] Jane C. Loeffler, "The Architecture of Diplomacy: Heyday of the United States Embassy building Program, 1954-1960", *Journal of the Society of Architectural Historians*, No. 49, September 1990, pp. 251-78.
[147] The International Style was characterized, inter alia, by bilateral symmetry, and horizontal lines, that are frequently broken by vertical lines, and in some cases, roofs that protrude beyond the external walls of the building - a description that fits the Knesset building to a surprising degree. (See Henry-Russell Hitchcock & Philip Johnson, The International Style, New York and London, W.W.Norton & Company, 1932).
[148] From the comments of Abba Elhanani at the Tvai symposium, op. cit. Apparently, it is not only the Knesset that may be attributed to the International Style, but also many parliaments in other new states. Lawrence Vale explains the phenomenon in that among the factors influencing the style of building in these countries, there is also the desire to prove that they belong to the modern world, in other words, the Western world. See Lawrence Vale, op. cit. p. 53.
[149] From the words of Emanuel Freedman, the building's engineer, during the discussion about monumental construction at the Tvai symposium.
[150] Yahuda Ha`ezrahi op. cit.
[151] Interview held by the writer with Ram Karmi, June 14, 1998.
[152] *Cathedra*, No. 96, Tamuz 5760, pp. 132-69.
[153] Gillitt, a non-Jewish Englishman, who was born in Chile (his father was engaged in railway construction in that state in the 1930s), studied architecture in London in the 1950s, together with Ram Karmi. In 1958 Karmi invited him to come to Israel and work in the "Karmi, Melzer and Karmi" office in Tel Aviv. Gillitt worked on several projects in the office (inter alia the planning of the Kameri Theater, the completion of Habimah, and the planning of the offices of the Institute of Standards), and in the beginning of 1960 prepared, together with Ram Karmi, the new plan for the Knesset building. After the plan was accepted by the Implementation Committee, he started to work as an employee of Ma'atz, as coordinating architect of the Knesset project. He left the project at the end of 1962, after the detailed plans of the building had been completed and approved, and settled in the United States with his Jewish wife. Today he lives in Newton Massachusetts. The interview with Gillitt was held in Cape Cod in the United States, on September 26, 2000.
[154] Ruegg, a non-Jewish Swiss, arrived in Israel in 1959, following a lecture by Moshe Shertok, that excited his imagination. He started to work for Joseph Klarwein in the summer of 1960 on the Jerusalem central bus station project. Ruegg left Klarwein after less than a year, but turned to him again in the summer of 1961 with a request that he help him find work, when Klarwein suggested that he join the team working on the Knesset project. He got to know Gillitt about a year before the latter left the country. Ruegg returned to Switzerland after his son, who had been born in Israel, reached the age of four, and because he was not satisfied with the atmosphere on the project. In Zurich he served for many years as the city's Chief Architect. The interview with Ruegg was held in Zurich in Switzerland on December 1, 2000.
[155] It was Prof. Avraham Diskin from the Political Science Department at the Hebrew University in Jerusalem, who as a youth had been employed by Solel Boneh for a summer job at the Knesset site, who gave me Segal's name, and the names of several additional persons from the Solel Boneh team. The interview with Segal was held in Jerusalem on
[156] See above.
[157] Ibid. p. 164. November 13, 2000.

[158] According to Gillitt, to the best of his memory, at this stage Ram Karmi was no longer involved in the project.
[159] Both Gillitt and Ruegg mentioned a young Israeli architect, who had worked as part of the professional team on the project - Ruth Melamed.
[160] He gave evidence in this spirit at a trial that took place in 1963 on a claim by the Karmi family against the Knesset, over money that it claimed the Knesset owed it. The Ma'atz engineer, Emanuel Friedman, on the other hand, argued that the plans had not been completed.

[161] See the original article.
[162] Ibid.
[163] Interview held by the writer with Hans Ruegg, December 1, 2000.
[164] See original article.
[165] Ibid. p, 151.
[166] Ibid.
[167] Explanations provided by both Gillitt and Ruegg in their interviews with the author.
[168] See my original article
[169] In the interview with the author, Gillitt used the English term “over-hang”.
[170] See the original article.
[171] Interview held by the writer with Segal, November 13, 2000. Stones designated for cutting must be sawed, since using explosives cracks them.

[172] See the original article.
[173] The Soviet Union conquered the Finnish town during the Second World War. Today it is in the Carelia province in Russia, and is known by the name of Vyborg.
[174] See the original article.